Hindust

## KHARIF YIELDS MAY BE AT RISK AS MONSOON LOSES MOMENTUM AGAIN

**Pallavi Singhal and Jasjeev Gandhiok**

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**NEW DELHI:** After pulling India back from a near 40% rainfall deficit at the end of June, the southwest monsoon is losing momentum again. The all-India rainfall deficit remained stuck at 12% as of August 13 despite widespread showers in the first half of August, and forecasts suggest rainfall could weaken further through the month. Soybean, maize, paddy and other kharif crops are now entering the growth stages that determine final yields, and experts say the next fortnight could decide whether the uneven monsoon dents productivity.

The sowing season has virtually ended. Agriculture ministry data show kharif crops were sown over an area about 2% lower than a year earlier as of August 14. →P2

## ARCELORMITTAL STEEL PLANT HIT AS UKRAINE, RUSSIA EXCHANGE STRIKES

**KYIV:** Strikes killed 16 people in Russia and Ukraine, authorities said Sunday, as waves of drones and missiles pummelled civilian infrastructure on both sides.

In Ukraine, a barrage of Russian drones and missiles killed two people and wounded 14 at ArcelorMittal's steel plant in Kryvyi Rih. In Russia, swarms of Ukrainian drones killed five people in a residential area of the southern Rostov region. Three more people were killed in the Belgorod, Kursk and Moscow regions. →P9

# Passenger's gun goes off at Varanasi airport, 2 hurt

**HT Correspondents**

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**VARANASI/NEW DELHI/MUMBAI:** Two airport personnel at Varanasi airport were injured on Sunday after a round was accidentally fired from a licensed pistol during a security check, officials said.

Airport director Puneet Gupta said the two were stable.

The Bureau of Civil Aviation Security (BCAS), the security wing of the Union civil aviation ministry, is examining the circumstances leading to the incident, a government statement said.

Kamlesh Rai, 55, and his wife Sushma were to travel to Mumbai on flight IX-1810, Gupta said.

"He declared he would carry his licensed weapon on the aircraft," Gupta said. Passengers carrying licensed firearms must declare the weapon at the check-in counter and complete the prescribed security formalities.

Police said Central Industrial Security Force (CISF) and airline staff were checking Rai's pistol and counting its cartridges before boarding. Authorised personnel from the airline and AAICLAS were entering details of the passenger's registered baggage and weapon. "Preliminary investigation revealed a round was in the pistol's chamber and that the trigger was accidentally fired while the pistol was loaded," the DCP's office said in a statement. →P5

### Loaded pistol, unexpected shot

**Two employees at Varanasi airport were injured after a round was accidentally fired from a passenger's licensed pistol during a routine security check.**

"BCAS is examining the circumstances leading to the incident, including adherence to the prescribed procedures for handling and carriage of licensed weapons..."
**— Civil aviation ministry**

**WHAT HAPPENED**

Security and airport staff were checking the pistol and counting its cartridges as part of the security process.

The pistol's magazine was removed to record its details, but a round remained in the chamber. The trigger was accidentally fired while the pistol was loaded.

# Delhi growth push takes two-pronged approach

**Snehil Sinha**

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**NEW DELHI:** The Capital will grow through a two-pronged strategy of redeveloping existing built-up areas, and opening new urban extensions through planned development to accommodate a projected population of nearly 32 million people, according to Delhi's 2047 Master Plan, which the Union government is likely to notify this week.

MASTER PLAN 2047

It focuses on rebuilding existing neighbourhoods, regenerating unauthorised colonies and other unplanned settlements, and creating denser, infrastructure-led urban extensions, proposing higher floor area ratios (FAR) for about four million new houses that Delhi will likely need for this burgeoning population.

The plan also links development to the availability of essential public services, including roads, public transit, sewerage, electricity and digital connectivity.

"The... infrastructure-first approach seeks to prevent unplanned growth and ensure that new communities continued on →7

## NAVY SAILOR, WIFE, 2 CHILDREN FOUND DEAD IN SUSPECTED MURDER-SUICIDE

**Megha Sood**

letters@hindustantimes.com

**MUMBAI:** A 30-year-old Indian Navy sailor and three members of his family were found dead at their residence in Navy Nagar area of south Mumbai on Saturday in a suspected case of murder-suicide, police said on Sunday.

DCP Maneesh Kalwaniya said the sailor died by suicide and his 28-year-old wife, three-year-old son and a two-month-old daughter died of poisoning.

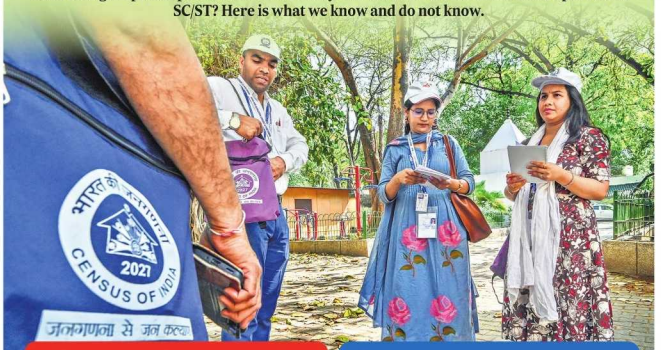
"We are attempting to put together the exact sequence of events preceding the deaths," an officer said. →P6

# NUMBER THEORY

# How will the 2027 Census count caste?

By Roshan Kishore, Abhishek Jha and Nishant Ranjan

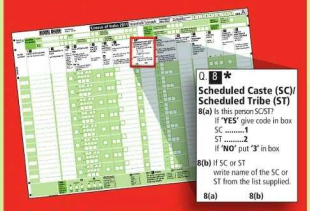
The gazette notification for the personal enumeration part of the 2027 Census was issued on August 14. The most awaited part of this phase of the Census is the caste enumeration that will happen for the first time in independent India. This practice was a part of Census operations under British rule but was discontinued. To be sure, the Census has been counting the Scheduled Caste (SC) and Scheduled Tribe (ST) population separately even in earlier iterations. What was not counted separately was the non-SC-ST population, which also includes the Other Backward Classes (OBCs). The biggest push for counting caste came from OBC groups and politicians. How exactly will the 2027 Census count caste apart from SC/ST? Here is what we know and do not know.



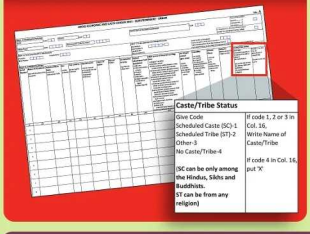

## 1 The gazette notification does not list OBCs as a category separately

Item 10 in the Household Schedule which was notified on August 14 talks about caste. The exact entry is "Scheduled Caste (SC)/ Scheduled Tribe (ST)/Caste". We will know more when the exact questionnaire is released when the self-enumeration exercise starts in Ladakh and snow bound areas of Jammu and Kashmir, Himachal Pradesh and Uttarakhand on August 17. However, it is useful to compare how the latest Census seeks information about caste with its predecessor.

The 2011 Census (image below) asked two related questions on caste: first to ascertain whether a person belonged to an SC or ST group; and second, the enumerator was instructed to "write name of SC or ST from the list supplied".




What the 2027 Census way of recording caste resembles is how the 2011 Socio Economic Caste Census tried to do it. The 2011 SECC questionnaire (below) asked two questions on caste: first, to ascertain whether a person was from an SC/ST/Other caste; and second, to record the caste name (no list was mentioned). The SECC caste data was never published officially. Neither the SECC nor the 2027 Census schedule mentions OBCs separately.




## 2 The challenge of listing OBC sub-castes

Does the 2027 Census have a list of all sub-castes in India? It is difficult to answer this question with confidence. And at least for official purposes there might not exist a universal list on this count. However, the Indian state does have a comprehensive list of OBCs at two levels: central list of OBCs and lists maintained by various states. Unlike SC/ST groups, whose recognition as such requires central government and the parliament's approval, states can notify sub-castes as OBCs on their own. As of now, there are 2,479 entries in the central list of OBCs. This number can be greater as a sum of states. For example, Tamil Nadu has 182 entries for OBCs in the Central list whereas the state government of Tamil Nadu has recognized 252 such entries in the state list. The Mandal Commission report, which forms the basis of the OBC reservations in India, recognised 3,743 communities as OBCs.

### Number of OBC entries in the central and state list

| STATE/UT | NUMBER OF OBC ENTRIES IN THE CENTRAL LIST | NUMBER OF OBC ENTRIES IN THE STATE LIST |
|---|---|---|
| Andhra Pradesh | 104 | 138 |
| Assam | 28 | 35 |
| Bihar | 132 | 142 |
| Chattisgarh | 67 | 95 |
| Gujarat | 105 | 146 |
| Haryana | 73 | 78 |
| Himachal Pradesh | 52 | 48 |
| Jammu and Kashmir | 23 | 42 |
| Jharkhand | 134 | 172 |
| Kerala | 83 | 98 |
| Madhya Pradesh | 68 | 92 |
| Maharashtra | 256 | 284 |
| Delhi | 56 | 65 |
| Odisha | 197 | 211 |
| Punjab | 65 | 75 |
| Rajasthan | 69 | 82 |
| Tamil Nadu | 182 | 252 |
| Telangana | 86 | 130 |
| Uttar Pradesh | 76 | 79 |
| West Bengal | 98 | 140 |

Deleted entries from states like Maharashtra, Telangana, and Odisha are excluded while counting the total. There are cases where some groups are OBC in particular districts and not throughout the state as in Kerala where 98 OBCs entries are for throughout the state and rest districtwise.
Source: Ministry of Justice & Empowerment, GOI and state websites and gazette notifications.

## 3 Unless the Census throws up granular sub-caste data, it may not be very illuminating compared to what we already know

This is the most important part. While the census has not been counting the OBC and non-SC-ST-OBC population separately, there exist government surveys which give us an estimate of the broad composition of the population on this count. The NFHS conducted in 2019-21 put the broad population share of SC-ST-OBC-Other population at 22%-9%-42%-27%. The PLFS conducted in 2025 puts the distribution at a similar 20%-9%-46%-24%. The experience from Bihar caste census, the results of which were published in 2023, suggest that the NSSO/NFHS numbers were not very off the mark.

### Share in Bihar's total population (%)

Source: PLFS; Bihar Caste Survey

Herein lies the dilemma which also characterised the debate around the caste census before it was made a part of the ongoing census. If the objective was to prove conclusively in census numbers that OBCs do have a population share of close to half in India's population, then the non-inclusion of a separate OBC category should have triggered protests. This does not seem to be happening as of now. If the aim was to study intra-group caste inequality – survey data once again shows this clearly but not on a sub-caste basis – then one might have to wait for the publication of the data to see what exactly comes out of the Census. Of course, unlike survey data, the government has never published granular details of Census data even before the debate around counting caste.

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EPAPER EDITION ■ EP: 6 / 195 ■ 14 PAGES.

BENGALURU/METRO
Monday, August 17, 2026

# Hindustan Times

FIRST VOICE. LAST WORD.

## NTA to re-conduct 3 NET papers marred by errors

**Sanjay Maurya**
letters@hindustantimes.com

**NEW DELHI:** The National Testing Agency (NTA) on Sunday said it will re-conduct the University Grants Commission National Eligibility Test (UGC-NET) exams for English, commerce and sociology, after a panel found a raft of factual, typographical and translation errors in the question papers, which also repeated portions from previous examinations.

The announcement, which impacts more than 20,000 candidates, comes months after the premier testing agency scrapped the May 3 NEET-UG examination after a paper leak. That cancellation affected 2.2 million students and sparked nationwide protests, including the Jantar Mantar agitation in Delhi that eventually prompted then Union education minister Dharmendra Pradhan to step down.

### APART FROM TYPOS, FACTUAL ERRORS, THE PAPERS ALSO REPEATED QUESTIONS FROM PREVIOUS EXAMS

"The Committee found that the three papers had many factual, typographical, translation errors including misspelt names of prominent scholars, garbled book titles, errors in the stem wording of questions, grammatical errors, gender and number agreement errors, punctuation mistakes, and non-standard coined terms for established concepts," NTA said in the notice, adding that the retests will be held on September 9 and 10.

An official aware of the matter said "14 questions" in the English paper were repeated from the December 2024 cycle.

The education ministry did not respond to emails and phone calls requesting comment on the matter.

UGC-NET determines eligibility for Junior Research Fellowships (JRF), assistant professor posts and PhD admissions. The exam is usually held twice a year, in June and December.

The decision follows complaints from candidates about errors and repeated questions in the three papers. Several sociology candidates also alleged

continued on →7

Tarique Rahman

## DHAKA SETS HASINA RIDER FOR RAHMAN'S VISIT TO INDIA

**Rezaul H Laskar**
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**NEW DELHI:** Bangladesh on Sunday set former premier Sheikh Hasina's extradition as a condition for a visit to India by Prime Minister Tarique Rahman, with the foreign ministry in Dhaka saying a "propitious environment" should be created for the trip to go ahead.

Foreign ministry spokesperson AKM Shahidul Karim also called on New Delhi to extradite "other fugitive criminals" — an apparent reference to leaders of Hasina's Awami League party currently in India — and to hand over the alleged killers of political leader Sharif Osman Hadi. →P2

## Census: Population count begins today

**Ravi Krishnan Khajuria, Shailee Dogra, Amit Bathla and Neeraj Chauhan**
letters@hindustantimes.com

**JAMMU/SHIMLA/DEHRADUN/NEW DELHI:** The landmark population enumeration phase of the 2027 Census will kick off on Monday with self-enumeration in the Union Territory of Ladakh and the snow-bound areas of Jammu and Kashmir, Himachal Pradesh and Uttarakhand, covering remote villages, mountainous communities and treacherous terrain.

Between August 17 and 31, residents in these regions can fill their details online. After this, census enumerators, armed with 40 questions notified last week – including those on the respondent's caste, parental details and identity documents – will launch a door-to-door exercise from September 1 till September 30. The counting of the population for the rest of the country will take place in February next year.

"The census data will be recorded through a paper-less exercise, similar to the houselisting exercise, using a mobile app in snow-bound areas. Before population enumeration is done, self enumeration will be done on https://se.census.gov.in," said chief principal census officer and director, census operations, J&K and Ladakh, Amit Sharma.

The operation will cover the around 274,000 people in Ladakh across seven districts. In Jammu and Kashmir, the exercise will comprise about 8.81 million people across 16 districts, including Doda, Poonch and Kupwara.

Challenges include villages in Zanskar with little road connectivity, Yingchen village in Leh comprising only 11 members from two families (seven hours by foot from the nearest hamlet), and Hanle village in Changthang, which sits at an altitude of around 15,000 feet.

"Certainly, there are peaks and high altitude areas where there will be few houses but we have deployed more special charges, especially where our forces, be it army or ITBP, are

continued on →7

### Stage set for Phase-2

**PHASE 1: HOUSELISTING AND HOUSING CENSUS**
**April 1-September 30:** 30-day enumeration period notified by each state/UT

**PHASE 2: POPULATION ENUMERATION**
**August 17-31:** Self-enumeration in Ladakh and snow-bound areas of J&K, Himachal Pradesh and Uttarakhand
**September 1-30:** Door-to-door enumeration in these areas
**October 1:** Reference date

**REST OF INDIA**
**February 2027:** Population enumeration
**March 1, 2027:** Reference date

**Areas covered**
**Ladakh:** 7 districts
**J&K:** 16 districts
**Himachal Pradesh:** 3 districts
**Uttarakhand:** 4 districts

## 4.8MN FORMS YET TO BE RETURNED AS KEY DELHI S.I.R. PHASE ENDS TODAY

**Saloni Bhatia**
letters@hindustantimes.com

**NEW DELHI:** Nearly 4.8 million enumeration forms — out of 14.5 million — distributed in Delhi under the Special Intensive Revision (SIR) are yet to be returned as of Sunday evening, a day ahead of the last date for the enumeration exercise in the Capital, with officials saying most of them belong to people who appear to have moved and are likely to be struck off the electoral roll.

## VIJAY SLAMS K'TAKA FOREST DEPT OVER KILLING OF 3 MEN

**CHENNAI/BENGALURU:** Tamil Nadu chief minister Vijay on Sunday condemned the killing of three men by the Karnataka forest department in the Cauvery Wildlife Sanctuary as a "massacre" and called for an impartial probe.

Vijay said the three men were Tamils and urged authorities to conduct an "honest investigation" into what he called a brutal incident. Karnataka authorities, however, described the three men as poachers, a charge their families have rejected. →P6

## Suspected suicide of TMC leader sparks political row

**HT Correspondent**
letters@hindustantimes.com

**KOLKATA:** Senior Trinamool Congress (TMC) leader and former West Bengal assembly deputy speaker Asish Banerjee was found dead at a party office on Sunday in a suspected case of suicide, triggering a political blame game in the state.

The 75-year-old Banerjee, a five-time MLA and a former state minister, visited the TMC office next to his Rampurhat residence in the morning, his relatives said. When he failed to respond to repeated calls, his family alerted the police, officials said.

Asish Banerjee

"It seems Banerjee died by suicide. A note, apparently written by Banerjee on his letterhead, says he was never involved in any corruption and that efforts were being made to tarnish his image," a police officer aware of the matter said on condition of anonymity. HT could not independently verify the authenticity of the letter.

In the purported note, Banerjee also said he made a mistake by joining politics and added that no member of his family should do so, officers said. "The note said he [Banerjee] was not involved in the tender process at TRDA," the officer quoted earlier said.

The Tarapith-Rampurhat Development Authority (TRDA) is a West Bengal government body responsible for development and planning in the Tarapith-Rampurhat area of Bir-

continued on →7

## SHAH HITS OUT AT SONIA AMID VANDE MATARAM FURORE

**JAIPUR:** Union home minister Amit Shah on Sunday targeted the Congress for allegedly insulting the national song, Vande Mataram, during an Independence Day programme, demanding an apology from the party. Meanwhile, complaints have been filed against Congress leaders Sonia Gandhi and Rahul Gandhi for allegedly disrespecting the national song during the flag-hoisting ceremony at the party headquarters. The Congress has denied the charges. →P5

## SC: TRIBUNALS CAN ORDER EVICTION TO PROTECT ELDERLY

**Utkarsh Anand**
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**NEW DELHI:** The Supreme Court has ruled that tribunals constituted under the Maintenance and Welfare of Parents and Senior Citizens Act, 2007 have the power to order eviction of persons from a property when such a measure is necessary to ensure the senior citizen's maintenance or protection. →P6

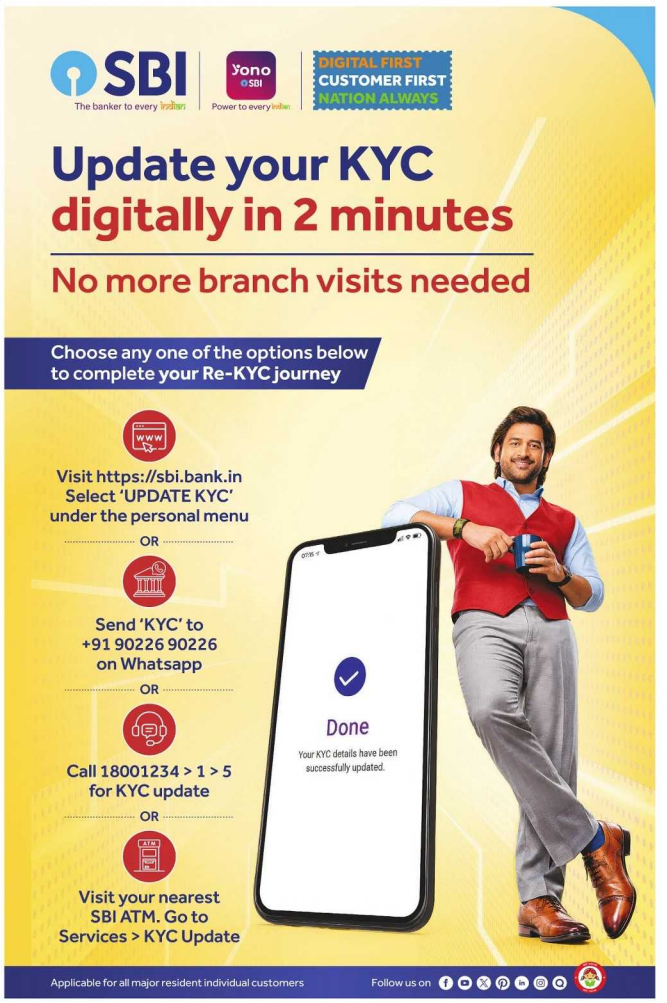
## GZB BIKER KILLED AFTER THROAT SLIT BY CHINESE MANJHA

**Arun Singh**
letters@hindustantimes.com

**GHAZIABAD:** A 25-year-old man bled to death after his throat was slit by a Chinese kite string while he was riding his motorcycle in Ghaziabad on Saturday, police said. His friend, who was riding pillion, controlled the bike and escaped unhurt. The victim was identified as Ravi Raj. "As they neared UP Gate, *manjha* slit Raj's neck," said Ajay Kumar Sharma, Kaushambi police SHO.

## B'DESH STUN AUS ON HOME TURF TO WIN FIRST TEST

**DARWIN:** Bangladesh completed a stunning nine-wicket victory over Australia in the first Test on Sunday, securing its first win on Australian soil. After making a vital half-century with the bat, Mehidy Hasan Miraz took five wickets for Bangladesh in the second innings to restrict Australia to a lead of just 56 runs, which the visitors chased down with one wicket down. →P12



# PAGE ONE PLUS

{ WORLD } INDONESIA EARTHQUAKE

## Rescue ops continue as toll increases to 53

**Around 5,000 people have been evacuated after** a magnitude-7 earthquake rocked eastern Indonesia, killing at least 53, authorities said on Sunday. They added that more than 130 people had been injured. Saturday's quake was the Southeast Asian nation's deadliest since a 2022 quake killed hundreds in West Java. More than 3,300 people in Indonesia's Sikka region - one of the hardest hit - self-evacuated or were in a sports arena, according to the country's national disaster mitigation agency, known as BNPB. The disaster agency said on Sunday nearly a thousand aftershocks had been recorded since the quake. More than 3,500 military and police officers have been deployed to the region, Cabinet Secretary Teddy Indra Wijaya said. Power supply was nearly fully restored, but authorities were still working on fixing distribution lines, state utility firm Perusahaan Listrik Negara said Sunday. REUTERS

{ WORLD } 'TAILOR MADE'

## Ferrari Luce fetches record price of $40mn

**Ferrari's first all-electric vehicle defied criticism** to sell for $40 million, making it the most expensive new car ever sold at auction. The Sotheby's charity auction of the Luce "tailor made" at Monterey Car Week in California broke a record posted last year, when Ferrari's customized Daytona SP3 sold for $26 million, the carmaker said in a statement. Ferrari in May unveiled the Luce, priced at €550,000 ($636,356) to a wave of criticism and a drop in the company's share price. The vehicle marks a break from Ferrari's heritage of combustion-engine sports cars. "Tailor made" cars are one-of-a-kind vehicles customised to a buyer's precise specifications. The model was designed with LoveFrom, the studio founded by Jony Ive. The car combines more than 1,000 horsepower with four doors. BLOOMBERG

{ SPORT } EARLY SEASON TRIUMPH FOR PL CHAMPS

## Arsenal humble Man City to win Community Shield

**Arsenal beat Manchester City 3-0 in the Community Shield on** Sunday, giving Mikel Arteta an early-season triumph while condemning new City boss Enzo Maresca to defeat in his first game in charge in the traditional curtain-raiser to the campaign. With their fourth victory over City in the fixture, Arsenal maintained their 100% win record over their opponents with an emphatic performance at the Principality Stadium where Riccardo Calafiori, Kai Havertz and Martin Odegaard found the net. Arteta's side used the annual curtain raiser to the English top-flight season as an opportunity to prove their long-awaited title triumph has done nothing to sate their appetite for success. The Gunners took just 24 seconds to show Maresca the standard required to keep up with the champions. Calafiori's quick-fire opening goal was followed by a clinical Havertz header before half-time. Odegaard netted after the interval to cap a resounding victory. AGENCIES

{ WORLD } IN SICILY

## 4 Renaissance works stolen from museum

**Thieves stole four works attributed to the** Sicilian Renaissance painter Antonello da Messina from a regional museum in the Sicilian city of Messina on the Italian Ferragosto holiday, the news agency LaPresse reported on Sunday. The thieves bypassed alarm and security systems Saturday evening at the MuMe regional museum to make off with three of the five surviving panels of the San Gregorio Polyptych, dated from 1473, as well as the double-sided panel depicting the Virgin Mary and dead Christ in Pietà, which was removed from an armoured display case, LaPresse reported. "It is a tremendous loss for the museum, the city, the community and the art world," MuMe director Marisa Mercurio told the ANSA news agency. She said the theft occurred just before 10pm. AP

{ WORLD } BUS WITH POLISH PILGRIMS

## 12 killed, 10 injured in bus crash in Hungary

**Twelve people were killed and at least 10** seriously injured after a Polish bus carrying 57 pilgrims veered off a motorway in eastern Hungary, in an accident that a survivor described as "unimaginable". Hungarian Prime Minister Peter Magyar said on Sunday in a Facebook post that the bus had run into a ditch and tipped over, at around 1 am. The bus, which also had two drivers on board, was returning to Poland from a shrine to the Virgin Mary at Medjugorje in southeastern Bosnia. The accident happened near the town of Mezokeresztes in eastern Hungary, police said, on the way towards the city of Nyiregyhaza. "A Polish-registered bus ... veered off the straight stretch of road into a ditch and overturned. Preliminary information suggests the driver likely fell asleep," police said on their website, adding that the driver was being taken into custody. REUTERS

# Monsoon falters again, puts kharif crop yields at risk

**Pallavi Singhal and Jasjeev Gandhiok**
letters@hindustantimes.com

KHARIF CROPS ARE NOW ENTERING GROWTH STAGES THAT DETERMINE FINAL YIELDS, AND NEXT FORTNIGHT COULD DECIDE IF UNEVEN MONSOON HITS PRODUCTIVITY

**NEW DELHI:** After pulling India back from a near 40% rainfall deficit at the end of June, the southwest monsoon is losing momentum again. The all-India rainfall deficit remained stuck at 12% as of August 13 despite widespread showers in the first half of August, and forecasts suggest rainfall could weaken further through the month. Soybean, maize, paddy and other kharif crops are now entering the growth stages that determine final yields, and experts say the next fortnight could decide whether the uneven monsoon dents productivity.

The sowing season has virtually ended. Agriculture ministry data show kharif crops were sown over an area about 2% lower than a year earlier as of August 14 — rice acreage down 3.7%, tur and maize by 4% each, cotton by 1% and sugarcane by 0.5%. With little room left for additional planting, this year's harvest will depend on yields, and on whether crops get adequate moisture through August and September.

### Monsoon recovery stalls

The national rainfall deficit has barely moved in a fortnight — from 13% below the long period average (LPA) on July 31 to 12% by August 13 — even as many parts of the country received regular showers this month.

In its July 31 long-range forecast, the IMD had projected below-normal rainfall for both August and September, estimating August rainfall at 94% of its long period average of 254.9 mm, with the first half of the month broadly normal before activity weakened later. Its August 13 extended-range forecast reinforces that outlook: near-normal rainfall from August 13-19, turning normal to below normal during August 20-26 as the monsoon trough shifts north again.

Mahesh Palawat, vice president at Skymet Weather, said the first half of August has prevented the rainfall deficit from worsening but has not delivered the widespread soaking rainfall needed to significantly improve the seasonal balance. "We expected some recovery during the first half of August, but substantial rainfall has been missing. Daily rainfall has remained close to the daily long period average... We now expect this to increase slightly after August 15 as the monsoon trough shifts towards the Himalayan foothills...," he told HT.

The all-India deficit conceals sharp regional variation.

### Deficit concentrated in food bowl

As of August 13, central India had almost erased its rainfall deficit, at just 1% below normal. Northwest India remained 11% below normal and the south peninsula 20% below average. East and northeast India saw the sharpest shortfall, still 27% below the long period average. Several agricultural states lag well behind normal: Bihar is down 39%, East Uttar Pradesh and Punjab 31% each, Jharkhand 25%, and the Haryana-Chandigarh-Delhi subdivision and West Uttar Pradesh around 11%. In the south, Karnataka is down over 21%, Kerala 22%, and parts of Andhra Pradesh over 30%.

IMD data show 40 of India's top 50 rice-producing districts are running rainfall deficits — as are 21 of the top 25 soybean districts, 18 of the top 21 tur districts and 16 of the top 20 maize districts.

### Timing matters for crops

Bhashkar Dubey, Assistant Professor and Agriculture Expert at KIT College, Prayagraj, said the district-level numbers matter more than the all-India deficit. "The biggest concern for kharif crops at this stage is not merely the cumulative rainfall deficit, but the uneven distribution of rainfall, prolonged dry spells and moisture availability during the crop's critical growth stages," he said.

Dubey said the 2026 monsoon shows why seasonal totals alone often fail to explain agricultural outcomes. "One or two days of heavy rain cannot compensate for a seasonal rainfall deficit. If heavy rainfall is followed by a long dry spell, soil moisture declines rapidly. This year, some districts have experienced flooding while others continue to struggle with rainfall deficiency and prolonged dry spells."

Crops are now entering the stages that determine final output. Soybean is particularly at risk, and continued moisture stress through late August could hurt flowering, pod formation and grain filling, reducing yields, Dubey said.

Dubey said most rice-producing districts are rainfall deficient, though irrigation could cushion production in several regions. Rainfed and upland paddy remain vulnerable if dry conditions persist during tillering, panicle initiation, flowering and grain filling. Tur, though relatively drought tolerant, could lose flowers and pods if moisture stress extends into its reproductive stage. Rainfed maize is vulnerable during tasselling, silking and grain filling; cotton faces risk from both dry spells and waterlogging.

Dr Vishwas Chitale, Fellow at the Council on Energy, Environment and Water (CEEW), said this year's monsoon reflects a longer-term shift — the monsoon is becoming more erratic, not simply wetter or drier. CEEW's assessment of four decades of rainfall data shows 55% of India's tehsils received over 10% higher southwest monsoon rainfall in the past decade compared with the 1982-2011 baseline, while 11% received over 10% less, concentrated across the Indo-Gangetic plains, the northeast and the Himalayan region. At the same time, 87% of tehsils recorded lower rainfall during June and July — the crucial sowing period — while 64% saw more heavy rainfall days each year, with precipitation arriving in shorter, more intense bursts. Nearly half the country's tehsils are also receiving more rainfall in October, suggesting a delayed monsoon withdrawal.

"For agriculture, this means the calendar farmers have relied upon for generations — when to sow, irrigate and harvest — is no longer a reliable guide. Adaptation planning has to move to the tehsil level," Chitale said.

# A chronicle of India's expanding aspirations

**PM Narendra Modi has over the years charted the country's progress and evolving ambitions in his Independence Day addresses. A look at some of his quotes over the years:**

### TOILETS TO SEMICONDUCTORS

**2014:** Can't we just make arrangements for toilets for the dignity of our mothers and sisters?

**2026:** ...Whether it is electronic goods, medical equipment, or transportation systems, chips are indispensable everywhere... That is why Bharat has begun establishing its own semiconductor manufacturing capacity in the direction of becoming self-reliant.

### RURAL ROADS, SPACE MISSION AND QUANTUM COMPUTING

**2016:** Rural roads are a perpetual issue in our country. Each rural citizen craves for pakka roads.

**2018:** Our scientists launched more than 100 satellites in one go, leaving the world astonished.

**2024:** I have noticed that there has been a new atmosphere of interest in science and technology in our schools and colleges after the success of Chandrayaan mission.

**2025:** We are preparing for Aatmanirbhar Bharat Gaganyaan on our own in space. We are working towards building our own space station...

**2026:** Today is the age of AI, quantum technology, space, robotics and data centres... Therefore, we must not merely turn our country into a market for the world, we must become a hub of innovation.

### FIGHT AGAINST POVERTY

**2014:** If the people of India could remove such a big empire without the power of the government... then friends, it is the need of the hour to eradicate poverty...

**2026:** The resolve for a developed India will be fulfilled only when development reaches the last person...We have provided social security cover to 100 crore countrymen within a decade.

### DIGNITY FOR WOMEN TO WOMEN-LED RESERVATION

**2014:** ...Has it ever pained us that our mothers and sisters have to defecate in the open?... Can't we just make arrangements for toilets for the dignity of our mothers and sisters?

**2018:** I declare with pride the grant of Permanent Commission for the appointment of women officers in Short Service Commission of Indian Armed Forces.

**2026:** Let us step forward to uphold their dignity and ensure that our mothers and sisters secure 33% representation in the legislative assemblies and the Lok Sabha as soon as possible...

### PUTTING FARMERS FIRST

**2014:** ... A farmer takes loan from the moneylender, but fails to repay... He will have to suffer hardships during his whole life. He chooses to commit suicide. Who will save the poor families of such farmers?

**2018:** Economists, farmer organisations, farmers as well as political parties had been demanding that farmers should get an MSP which is one and a half times of their investment. The matter was debated for years...We took a bold decision of giving the farmers the MSP which is one and half times their investment.

**2025:** Last year, the farmers of my country broke all previous records in the production of grains... Agro products worth 4 lakh crore rupees have been exported.

**2026:** Our farmers now have access to global markets. Because of FTAs, we are getting access to a very large market... We have to move from the farm to the export market...

### START-UP INDIA

**2015:** I have to provide strength to start-up and, therefore, I resolve that in the coming days "Start-up India" and "Stand-up India" will be there.

**2016:** There should not be any district, any block in Hindustan where start-ups are not initiated in the coming days...

**2026:** ...We have opened up the startup sector. You must have seen that private startups in Bharat, led by young people...launched their satellites and rockets...

### SELF-RELIANCE IN MANUFACTURING AND TECHNOLOGY

**2014:** ...From electrical to electronics, 'Come, Make in India', from automobiles to agro value addition, 'Come, Make in India', paper or plastic, 'Come, Make in India', satellite or submarine 'Come, Make in India'.

**2025:** ...By the end of this very year, 'Made in India' chip, manufactured in Bharat by the people of Bharat, will be available in the market...From operating systems to cyber security, from deep tech to artificial intelligence, everything should be our own...

**2026:** We must significantly advance the manufacturing sector. Alongside boosting production, we need to manufacture everything from small components to large-scale products.

### VILLAGE ELECTRIFICATION TO NUCLEAR ENERGY EXPANSION

**2015:** ...The target of providing electric poles, electric wires and electricity to these 18,500 villages would be achieved within next 1,000 days.

**2026:** ... By passing the SHANTI Act.. we have paved the way towards a new goal. By 2047, we are working towards a target of 100 gigawatts of nuclear power. Within this very decade, we have set a target of starting five new nuclear reactors.

### INTERNET CONNECTIVITY

**2015:** You can imagine what quality education the children in villages will get if all the villages of India are connected with broadband connectivity...

**2024:** We have also seen the days when we had to struggle even for 2G. We are already working in the mission mode for 6G and we shall surprise the world with our progress.

**2026:** The number of internet users and consumers has increased nearly fourfold. The number of patents granted has increased fourfold. Digital transactions have increased 100 times.

### COMBATING NAXALISM

**2017:** I deeply appreciate the efforts of security forces in curbing the Left-Wing Extremism which mobilised a lot of youth from these regions to surrender and join the mainstream.

**2018:** ...Because of continuous efforts by our security forces, launching of development projects and efforts to connect the people with the national mainstream, Left-Wing Extremism, which affected 126 districts, has now been reduced to 90 districts.

**2025:** There was a time when Naxalism had taken root in more than 125 districts. Our tribal areas and youth were caught in the clutches of Maoism. Today, we have reduced that number... to merely 20.

**2026:** ... In areas where Naxalites once fired their guns, where the land was once stained with blood, today, in those very Naxal-affected regions... the Tricolour of development, trust and endeavour is flying high.

### BANK ACCOUNTS TO UPI AND GLOBAL FINTECH DOMINANCE

**2015:** Even after sixty years of Independence... 40% people of the country were without a bank account... the doors of the banks were not open for the poor.

**2025:** Our own UPI platform is surprising the world today... India alone is doing 50% of the real-time transactions through UPI.

**2026:** We have already demonstrated our capabilities through UPI and digital public infrastructure... Now Bharat must take its digital public technologies to every corner of the world.

# B'desh sets Hasina extradition rider for Rahman's visit

**Rezaul H Laskar**
letters@hindustantimes.com

B'DESH CALLED ON INDIA TO EXTRADITE 'OTHER FUGITIVE CRIMINALS' AND TO HAND OVER THE ALLEGED KILLERS OF THE POLITICAL LEADER SHARIF OSMAN HADI

**NEW DELHI:** Bangladesh on Sunday set former premier Sheikh Hasina's extradition as a condition for a visit to India by Prime Minister Tarique Rahman, with the foreign ministry in Dhaka saying a "propitious environment" should be created for the trip to go ahead.

Foreign ministry spokesperson AKM Shahidul Karim also called on New Delhi to extradite "other fugitive criminals" — an apparent reference to leaders of Hasina's Awami League party currently in India — and to hand over the alleged killers of political leader Sharif Osman Hadi, who were arrested in West Bengal earlier this year.

The demand came against the backdrop of reports that India and Bangladesh are exploring the possibility of a bilateral visit by Rahman later this month as part of efforts to reset the overall relationship after nearly two years of unprecedented strains.

Karim, who made a statement on the issue at the foreign ministry, acknowledged that Bangladesh and India have been in touch for "several weeks" on the possibility of a visit by Rahman to New Delhi. His remarks appeared to play down reports that Rahman was certain to travel to India this month.

"However, this process was vitiated by the open press interaction in New Delhi on August 5 by Sheikh Hasina, who has been convicted by the International Crimes Tribunal for committing crimes against humanity," he said.

"We are of the view that a propitious environment needs to be created for this visit," Karim said. "To this end, we have requested the Indian authorities to expeditiously act on our request to extradite Sheikh Hasina and other fugitive criminals and to hand over to Bangladesh the accused killers of Shaheed Sharif Osman Hadi in compliance with our bilateral extradition treaty."

The Bangladeshi side is waiting for India's response on these matters, Karim said. He made it clear the government in Dhaka will continue to follow a "Bangladesh First" policy while pursuing friendly relations with other countries, including neighbours, on the "basis of sovereign equality, national dignity, non-interference in each other's internal affairs and mutual benefit".

There was no immediate response from Indian officials to Bangladesh's demands. The external affairs ministry has said that Bangladesh's request for Hasina's extradition is being examined in line with established legal processes. In the case of Hadi's alleged killers, the external affairs ministry said investigations are ongoing against the two Bangladeshi nationals arrested in West Bengal in March.

Though the Indian government had distanced itself from Hasina's news conference, Bangladesh expressed outrage at the event being organised on Indian soil, especially as she is a wanted fugitive following her conviction by the International Crimes Tribunal. The tribunal sentenced Hasina to death for ordering the use of lethal force against protesters in 2024.

The Bangladesh government had also raised Hasina's extradition when Indian high commissioner Dinesh Trivedi met PM Rahman in Dhaka on August 10. Trivedi subsequently travelled to New Delhi to brief Prime Minister Narendra Modi on the latest developments on August 11.

The two sides are discussing a possible bilateral visit by Rahman before the end of this month as he is expected to skip the Brics Summit being hosted by India in September, to which he was invited in his capacity as the current chairman of the Bimstec grouping. There is a very short window for a bilateral visit as the Indian PM will be occupied with foreign visits and other engagements in the coming months.

If it goes ahead, this will be Rahman's first visit to India since becoming PM in February, and it will follow his earlier trips to Malaysia and China.

Hasina's presence in India has emerged as a key irritant in the bilateral relationship, especially as she has continued to make statements from Indian soil, including her announcement about her plans to return home by December.

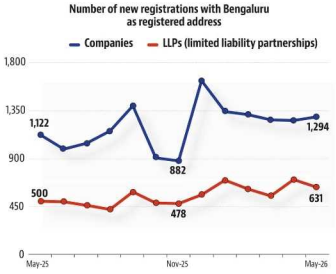
A visit by Rahman would provide the two sides an opportunity to address differences on important issues such as trade-related restrictions, transit, connectivity, border management, visas and water-sharing.

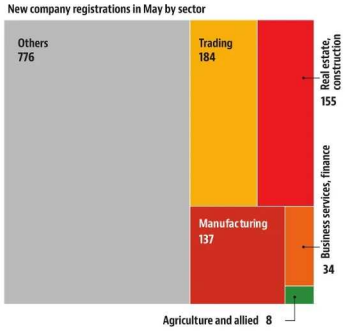
A monthly data dive into how the city is doing on 8 aspects that define quality of life for a citizen. Where are they improving, where are they worsening? **By howindialives.com**

# Tracking liveability index of India's IT hub

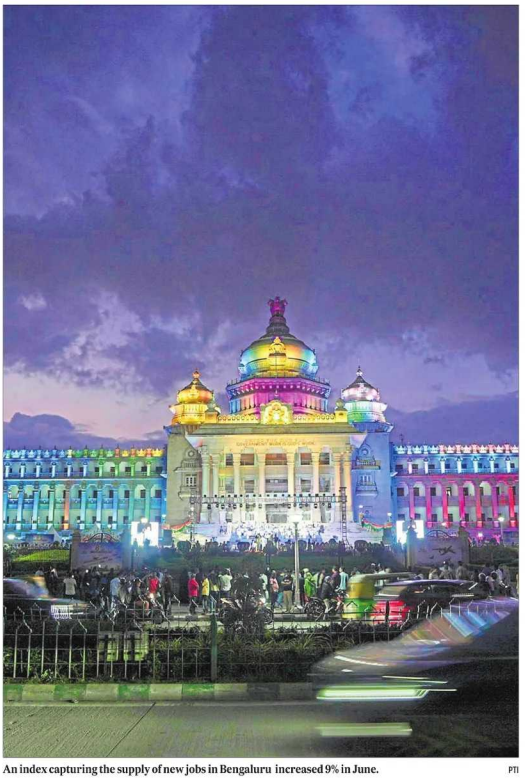
## NEW BUSINESSES

The number of new companies registered remained above the 1,000 mark in February, the latest available.



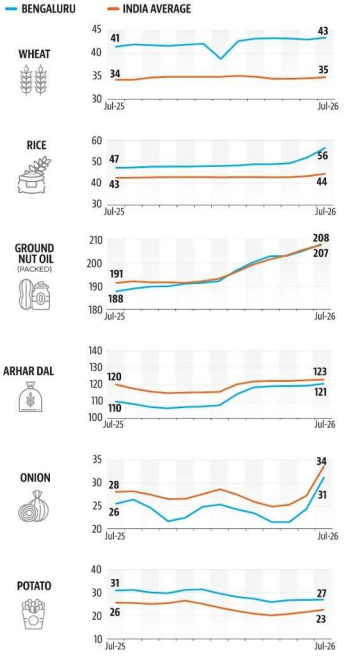

Source: Ministry of Corporate Affairs, howindialives.com calculations



An index capturing the supply of new jobs in Bengaluru increased 9% in June. PTI

## FOOD ITEMS

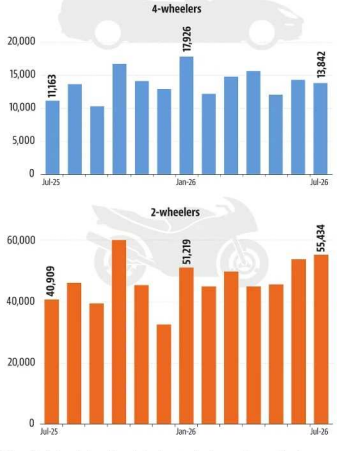
In June, prices of 3 of the 6 food commodities tracked for Bengaluru increased, led by rice and onions.




Note: All figures are Rs per kg. State averages used for city.
Source: Department of Consumer Affairs

## NEW VEHICLE REGISTRATIONS

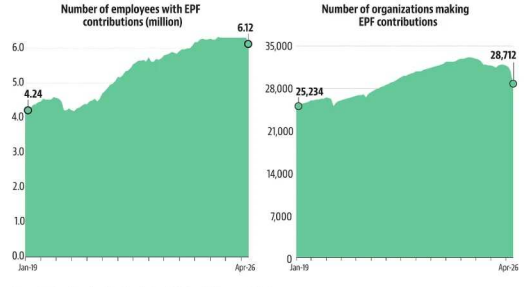
2-wheeler and 4-wheeler registrations in June rose 26% and 24%, respectively, over June 2025.




Note: Data for two-wheelers and four-wheelers for personal use (as opposed to comercial use)
Source: Vahan, howindialives.com calculations

## FORMAL SECTOR JOBS

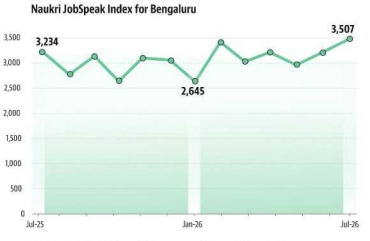
In April 2023, 31,067 organizations registered in Bengaluru deposited provident fund on behalf of their 5.68 million employees. In the past three years, till April 2026, the latest available, this total count of employees has increased by about 8%.




Source: Employees' Provident Fund Organisation (EPFO), howindialives.com calculations

## JOB POSTINGS

An index capturing the supply of new jobs in Bengaluru increased 9% in June.

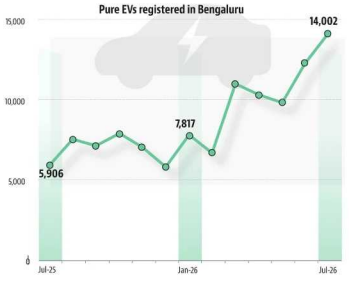



Note: The monthly Naukri JobSpeak Index is a measure of hiring activity based on job listings posted on Naukri.com by its clients. July 2008 is taken as the base, with an index value of 1,000, and values for subsequent months are calibrated to it. The index does not cover gig employment, hyperlocal hiring and campus placement.

Source: Naukri.com

## ELECTRIC VEHICLES

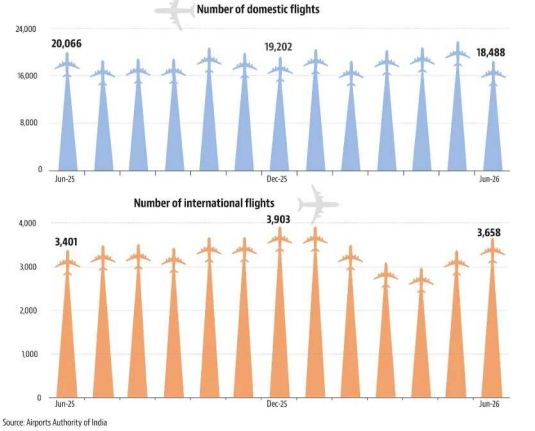
The number of new pure EVs registered in June was the highest monthly levels in the past year.




Source: Vahan, howindialives.com calculations

## AIR TRAFFIC

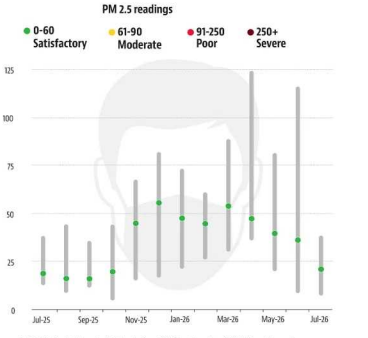
In May 2026, the number of domestic flights from Bengaluru increased 3% over May 2025 levels, while international flights fell 7%.




Source: Airports Authority of India

## AIR QUALITY

Average air quality stayed in the 'satisfactory' zone in June, amid an improvement.




Note: 1. We took daily values for the station at Silk Board Junction at 4 PM. Thus, the median value for a month is the daily value where the number of days above it equals the number of days below it. 2. PM 25, also a part of AQI calculation, is a prominent pollutant. The particles are fine and can only be detected with an electron microscope.

Source: Central Pollution Control Board

**howindialives.com** is a database and search engine for public data

# SOUTH REGION

## TN's stand on Mekedatu non-negotiable: Tagore

**Press Trust of India**
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B Manickam Tagore

**MADURAI:** Tamil Nadu Congress Committee (TNCC) president B Manickam Tagore on Sunday said that Tamil Nadu's stance against the Mekedatu dam is non-negotiable and urged the Centre to firmly deny permission for Karnataka's proposed Mekedatu reservoir project, asserting that any approval would severely harm the state's interests.

Addressing a press conference here, Tagore questioned the silence of regional leaders, including PMK leader Anbumani Ramadoss and BJP leader Nainar Nagendran, over the Karnataka BJP unit opposing the release of Cauvery water to Tamil Nadu.

"Prime Minister Narendra Modi should not grant clearance for the project under any circumstances, regardless of demands from leaders across party lines in Karnataka," he said, adding that Tamil Nadu must stand united and pursue legal remedies in the Supreme Court to secure its rightful water share.

Tagore also strongly condemned remarks by Nagenthran, characterising them as "third-rated" and unacceptable, and demanded an unconditional apology. He emphasised that political leaders must maintain decorum and respect toward women.

Taking a jibe at Tamil Nadu chief minister C Joseph Vijay, Nagenthran, at an event at the BJP state headquarters (Kamalalayam) on August 15, said: "When people search for a father in the House and cannot find him, they should ask the mother at home to know who the father is."

Reacting to PM Modi's Independence Day address regarding "ideological Naxals," the Congress Lok Sabha member defended former Union Minister P Chidambaram's sarcastic response on social media.

Chidambaram posted on his official 'X' account that he is "proud to be a dimagi naxal". Tagore alleged that the Centre tends to label anyone advocating for wealth redistribution and socialist welfare policies as Naxals.

He also dismissed the prime minister's announcement regarding AI training for one crore youth, calling it an unfulfilled claim amid rising unemployment among educated youth nationwide.

On the delay in the construction of the All India Institute of Medical Sciences (AIIMS) in Madurai, Tagore alleged that the Centre has continually shifted goalposts despite funding assistance from Japan.

He stated that MPs from southern districts would continue raising the issue in Parliament until the facility is fully established. Tagore also dismissed the rumours that DMK MP Kanimozhi's presence at the Lok Sabha Speaker's customary end-of-session tea meeting was politically significant. He clarified that attending the meeting was a standard parliamentary courtesy.

"INDIA bloc parties chose to boycott the meeting specifically to register their protest against Union Home Minister Amit Shah's prolonged absence during the session," he added.

Tagore also lauded the TVK-led Tamil Nadu government's measures regarding women's safety and its crackdown on narcotics syndicates.

He supported the state's efforts to plug revenue leakages in sectors like minerals and registration to overcome fiscal challenges and implement welfare schemes.

Major and medium irrigation and district minister N Chaluvarayaswamy said the state government aims to lay the foundation stone for the Mekedatu project by August next year.

At a press conference in Mandya on Saturday, the minister made key announcements on the state's irrigation projects and the Cauvery water dispute.

## We will protect the interests of our farmers: Shivakumar

**Press Trust of India**
letters@hindustantimes.com

**MADIKERI:** Karnataka chief minister D K Shivakumar on Sunday said that his government has a dual challenge of protecting the livelihood of farmers and also abiding by the law on the issue of releasing Cauvery water to Tamil Nadu.

Invoking rain gods to emerge from the crisis, the CM assured the state's farmers that their livelihood would be kept in mind while taking decisions on the matter. He also asserted that the state's interests will be protected when it comes to the implementation of the Mekedatu project.

"Our dams have not filled yet. We have two big challenges: Releasing water to Tamil Nadu, abiding by the law, and protecting our farmers. Certainly we will protect the interests of our farmers. It is my duty too," Shivakumar said.

Speaking to reporters after visiting a temple at Bhagamandala in Kodagu district, he said the government has a duty to provide water for drinking and agriculture.

"Depending on the availability of water at dams, we have to release it to farmers for their crops. Our wish is that there should be good rainfall, crops should flourish, and farmers should have food and livelihood," he added.

Noting that the Supreme Court has stated there is no objection to constructing any dam within the state, the CM, while speaking on the Mekedatu project said, the Central government also made this clear when responding to a Tamil Nadu MP's query in the Parliament.

He further asserted that he and his government were committed to protecting the interests of the state on this matter.

Mekedatu is a multi-purpose project (drinking water and power) proposed by Karnataka, which involves building a balancing reservoir near Kanakapura in Bengaluru South district. Tamil Nadu opposes the project, fearing that the state would be affected if it is built.

Reiterating that the construction of the Mekedatu project will not affect Tamil Nadu's allocated share of 177.25 TMC of water, Shivakakumar said, there are separate formulas for water sharing during distress years.

The Cauvery Water Management Authority has issued certain directions. "If there is any crisis, a situation may come where we may have to give the dam keys to the Centre. That should not happen. We have to protect the livelihood of our farmers and also protect and abide by the law. This is very important. To overcome all these, we need blessings of rain gods and all of us should pray for them," he said.

DK Shivakumar

The Cauvery Water Regulation Committee (CWRC), which met in New Delhi last Tuesday, asked Karnataka to release 12,000 cusecs of water per day starting August 12 for the next 15 days. The Cauvery Water Management Authority (CWMA), the appellate body, subsequently upheld this decision.

The state government has planned to appeal against the CWMA's order in the Supreme Court. Responding to a question on BJP national general secretary B L Santosh's reported statement that the RSS will not register, in the wake of the state government's proposed Bill against unauthorised use of public property -- allegedly aimed at curtailing the Sangh's activities -- Shivakumar said, there is no need for the RSS or Santosh to worry.

He added that the proposed legislation is not aimed at anyone, and everyone should function according to the law.

"We don't want to hurt anyone's feelings. Whichever religion or organisation, they must follow law... If an organisation submits an application seeking permission from the government, the necessary permission and staff arrangements will be provided according to the rules," he said.

Responding to a question on Santosh's statement, Shivakumar said, "He is a senior leader. Let us also listen to his guidance. We have only provided greater clarity regarding the provisions that already exist in the law. Nobody needs to panic."

### CM turns 'Modi-Modi' chants into 'DK-DK'

After a section of the crowd started chanting "Modi Modi" during a program at Vidhan Soudha, Karnataka Chief Minister DK Shivakumar tackled the situation head-on with a quick-witted comeback that turned the chants around in his own favour.

Rather than let the moment pass by ignoring the chants, CM Shivakumar responded to the chants directly from the stage, telling the crowd, "Even Modi says DK DK" The remark drew a swift reaction from the gathering, with the crowd then breaking into chants of "DK, DK" in response. He then responded with "Look, DK, DK chants have started now". CM Shivakumar has previously brushed off similar sloganeering in his favour, when some people chanted DK-DK infront of Congress general secretary (organisation) KC Venugopal in December 2025. Shivakumar also attended the Independence Day celebrations held at the Congress office in Bengaluru on the occasion of Independence Day .

## BJP leader PC George makes U-turn on party poll fund fraud claims

**HT Correspondent**
letters@hindustantimes.com

PC George

**THIRUVANANTHAPURAM:** BJP leader and former Poonjar MLA PC George on Sunday made a U-turn on allegations of misappropriation of election funds in his constituency within the party that he had made publicly at a party meeting in July, officials said on Sunday.

George (74), at an election review meeting in Erumely in July, had said that funds allocated by the party's central unit for the election campaign in Poonjar had been misappropriated with even booth committees failing to receive money.

He had claimed that ₹4.45 crore had reportedly been allocated for the constituency during the Assembly election, but that a large portion of which had been misappropriated with some party leaders even buying cars with the loot.

He named Saji Kurikkad, the party's general secretary in charge of central region, as responsible for handling the money.

After the comments sparked row, the BJP leader made a U-turn on Sunday and claimed that two BJP leaders had misled him on the expenditure.

"The party leadership showed me the accounts. Even expenditure of ₹100 had been accounted for. I am now convinced that nobody stole the party funds," he told reporters.

George said that he made a mistake in Erumely through the remarks he made and stated that Kurikkad was a respected person.

"I made a mistake and I apologise," he said.

BJP state chief Rajeev Chandrasekhar claimed that the allegations of misappropriation of election funds was a "media creation."

"Most of the news in this regard are not factually correct," he said.

He said there was no question of him leaving the party. "I only have one father, that is honourable Narendra Modi. There is no question of changing," he said.

George also stated that he lost the Poonjar seat after the Christian community had decided to unite behind the UDF.

## FREQUENT FIGHTS, ANGER ISSUES LED TO B'LURU TECHIE MURDER: POLICE

**HT Correspondent**
letters@hindustantimes.com

**BENGALURU:** Frequent quarrels and anger issues are believed to have led to the death of a 29-year-old woman, who was allegedly strangled by her husband before he died by suicide at their rented house in Rajarajeshwari Nagar on Friday, police said on Sunday.

The deceased have been identified as Padmavathi. Police said the couple, who had married around four years ago after being in a relationship, had been facing frequent disagreements over domestic issues and husband's work schedule.

North west Deputy Commissioner of Police D L Nagesh said the preliminary investigation suggested that a heated argument between the couple escalated into the fatal incident.

"Our investigation so far indicates that frequent quarrels and their excessive anger were the immediate factors behind the incident. There was no indication of any pre-planned murder at this stage. We are examining all aspects of the case," Nagesh said. Deceased husband , a civil engineer (32), working at a private company in Nandini Layout. Police said husband had sent a WhatsApp voice message to his mother shortly before taking the extreme step. He had asked her to take his provident fund and belongings from the house.

## Freedom Habba carnival

Fireworks light up the sky over the Vidhana Soudha during a musical event as part of the 'Freedom Habba' carnival to mark the 80th Independence Day, in Bengaluru on Saturday. PTI

## HMT launches spl edition watches, draws 2.5-km-long queue in B'luru

**Hirekop Rajan Samuel**
letters@hindustantimes.com

**BENGALURU:** A 2.5-km-long queue of customers formed in Bengaluru on Saturday to purchase special-edition watches released by Hindustan Machine Tools (HMT) to mark the 80th Independence Day.

Union minister for heavy industries and steel HD Kumaraswamy, who is working to revive the HMT factory, said he was surprised by the strong public demand for the watches.

"The sight of people standing in a queue for nearly two kilometres to buy HMT watches shows how deeply the popularity and legacy of the HMT brand remain rooted in the hearts of people," Mr Kumaraswamy said.

HMT chairman and managing director Ramesh said the company had launched a limited-edition series of watches on the occasion of Independence Day. The special watches featuring the Tricolour and the Gandaberunda emblem were completely sold out, he said.

> UNION MINISTER HDK, WHO IS WORKING TO REVIVE THE HMT FACTORY, SAID HE WAS SURPRISED BY THE DEMAND

"More watches will be manufactured and released by the end of next month. We will also introduce high-quality automatic watches for sale," he said.

Customers lined up outside the HMT factory outlet at Jalahalli to purchase the watches. HMT has three outlets in Bengaluru, and stocks at the Jalahalli outlet and the HMT Bhavan outlet near Mekhri Circle were sold out within a day. Kumaraswamy said he was delighted to see people queueing up to buy HMT watches. "We all grew up seeing HMT watches. I am amazed to see that people continue to have such strong affection for these watches even today," he said.

## Hanur shootout: Kin call off stir after MLA assures ₹15 lakh relief

**Coovercolly Indresh**
letters@hindustantimes.com

**BENGALURU:** Families of the three men killed in the firing incident in the Shagya range of the Cauvery Wildlife Sanctuary and residents of surrounding villages called off their protest on Sunday after Hanur MLA MR Manjunath assured them of compensation and action against those found responsible, officials said on Sunday.

The families had been staging a protest in Hanur, demanding compensation, government jobs for the dependants of the deceased and strict action against the forest officials involved in the firing. MLA Manjunath visited the protest site and held discussions with the protesters. He assured them that each of the three families would receive compensation, with the total amount amounting to ₹15 lakh. "The government has announced ₹5 lakh as immediate compensation. I will personally provide another ₹10 lakh. Thus, the families will receive a total of ₹15 lakh. I will also speak to the government regarding providing jobs to the dependants of the deceased," Manjunath said. He also assured the families that action would be taken against officials if they were found guilty in the investigation.

> THE FAMILIES HAD BEEN STAGING A PROTEST SEEKING COMPENSATION, GOVERNMENT JOBS FOR DEPENDANTS OF THE DECEASED, STRICT ACTION AGAINST THE FOREST OFFICIALS

"The government has entrusted the investigation to a magistrate. If any officials are found responsible, action will be taken against them, including suspension. The investigation will bring out the truth," he said. The protesters agreed to temporarily withdraw their agitation following the assurances. Farmer leaders said they would resume the protest if the government failed to fulfil its promise.

An FIR has already been registered against forest department officials and personnel.

### TN CM Vijay condemns killings of 3 Tamils

Tamil Nadu chief minister C Joseph Vijay on Sunday strongly condemned the killing of three Tamilians who were allegedly suspected to be poachers by Karnataka forest department officials, calling the department's explanation of the incident "unacceptable".

In a post on X, the official handle of Vijay's Tamilaga Vettri Kazhagam (TVK) said the circumstances surrounding the deaths required a thorough and impartial investigation, and criticised the explanation given by the Karnataka forest department. "...I strongly urge the Karnataka government to take appropriate measures to ensure that no such incident occurs again," Vijay added.

## Kerala's baby cradle scheme hits milestone: 1,000th infant rescued

**Vishnu Varma**
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**THIRUVANANTHAPURAM:** It was on the eve of Christmas in 2002. G Sasidharan, then a novice programme officer with the Kerala State Council for Child Welfare (KSCCW), remembers the day like it was only yesterday. Around 1:30 am, when most of Thiruvananthapuram had drifted off to sleep, a siren rang in the nursing station inside the KSCCW, then nestled in a small building on Gandhi Bhavan Road, he said. It was a watershed moment – a baby had been 'received' at the 'Ammathottil' (mother cradle) facility in front of the building.

Within two minutes, caregivers and security officials at KSCCW rushed towards the cradle, scooped up a few days-old baby girl and proceeded to give her urgent medical care. Sasidharan, who had gone home, rushed to the office along with other staff, filled with excitement.

"We were all curious and interested, to see what she looked like. It was a big deal. She was named Nithya," said Sasidharan, now a legal consultant and personal assistant to the KSCCW general secretary. "She stayed with us for about a year before being adopted by a family."

The arrival of Nithya and her subsequent adoption was vindication for those like Sasidharan and others at KSCCW that the idea and the system worked. On November 14, Children's Day, 2002, MK Muneer, then minister for social justice, had inaugurated 'Ammathottil' – a project that grants parents a safe, anonymous way to give up their infants rather than abandoning them or causing harm to them.

It's a modest electronic cradle, in a cabin with electronic doors and sensors that would light up and send signals when a baby is placed in it.

The parents can quietly slip away while the baby gets turned over to the safe guardianship of the State.

Cut to August 4, 2026, at 3:35 am, the 'Ammathottil' project marked a significant milestone when the 1,000th infant was 'dropped off' inside the electronic cradle outside the KSCCW building in the state capital. Just five days old and weighing 2.57 kilograms, she was named 'Sahasra' – the Sanskrit word for one thousand.

'Ammathottil' was inaugurated on November 14, 2002, a project that grants parents a safe, anonymous way to give up their infants rather than abandoning them. HT PHOTO

"She is the light of a thousand hopes," described GL Arun Gopi, the general secretary of KSCCW, who named the infant girl.

Among the 1,000 infants received in 'Ammathottil' facilities across the state over the last 24 years, at least 97% have been adopted by families in India and abroad.

Of them, 681 were girls and the remaining 319 boys. Even twins have been received over the years and gone on to find safe abodes. Over 65% of the infants were received at the facility in Thiruvananthapuram.

In an ideal world, Gopi said, 'Ammathottil' facilities shouldn't exist. "That's the dream," he said.

"But, due to various social factors, people are forced to surrender their children at our facilities. A woman may have been forced to become a mother for several reasons. She must not be made to feel like a criminal. The society must not grill her. Only then can this problem be solved to a large extent," he added.

### From 0 to 1000: A 24-year journey

The idea of the 'Ammathottil' germinated in the minds of the then KSCCW governing council members in 2002 after a few heartbreaking episodes of infants being abandoned in public places.

In one incident, an abandoned infant, just days old, was found to have been mauled and dragged away by stray dogs outside the SAT Hospital in Thiruvananthapuram city that year – a case that had huge ramifications in Kerala, a state known for superior health infrastructure. In another incident, a baby left behind in a rubber estate was found to be swarming with ants and worms.

"It was at that time that some students from the Thiruvananthapuram engineering college proposed the concept of a facility with sensors and automatic doors where a baby can be received safely. The idea was implemented in the state capital in November 2002 and replicated in Malappuram district the same year," said Sasidharan.

Today, in 11 of the state's 14 districts, there are such electronic cradles located near district or taluk hospitals. In Kannur, Wayanad and Idukki districts, work is ongoing to build new high-tech cradle facilities after the old ones fell into disrepair.

Once an infant is received in an 'ammathottil', the information is relayed to the nearest police station and the child welfare committee (CWC), underlined Gopi. After being administered first aid, the infant is shifted to a government hospital for a medical check-up.

"The baby's health is assessed. If he/she is medically fit, they are brought to the KSCCW or the district adoption centres where nursing facilities are available. We then put out newspaper ads about the baby being received and wait for 60 days to see if the parents turn up. If no one turns up, the infant is certified as 'legally fit for adoption' (LFA) and its information is passed on to the Central Adoption Resource Authority (CARA)," he said. If parents turn up to reclaim their children within the stipulated 60-day time period, necessary DNA tests are conducted to verify the claim. In the last three years, there have been 4-5 such cases of parents coming forward to stake claims, the general secretary said.

Infants come with several kinds of health complications, he said, including being born premature, with physical and mental shortcomings and reduced body weight.

"Once, we received a baby which weighed just 900 grams. We nurtured the baby here till it was 1.5 years old by using a special caretaker. The baby was later adopted by a couple who lived abroad," said Gopi.

"We believe every infant coming in has the right to lead a dignified life and grow up as a positive individual, like every other child born across the world. Once we receive a child, we draw up special health plans for it and ensure adequate care. It's a big responsibility," he pointed out.

The KSCCW headquarters in Thiruvananthapuram has elaborate nursing facilities for infants, including wards and special rooms. It has a staff strength of 110 comprising ayahs, caretakers, nursing supervisors, social workers and counsellors, all of whom are contractual employees, working in shifts round the clock. Paediatricians from government hospitals drop in when required to check up on the children. By January 2027, a 'human milk bank' is set to be installed at KSCCW in the state capital, which would allow mothers to donate their breast milk for the infants being cared for at adoption centres across the state. Once realised, Kerala would be the first state to have such a facility, said officials.

# Vande Mataram row: Shah targets Sonia, Cong hits back

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Amit Shah, Sonia Gandhi

**JAIPUR:** Union home minister Amit Shah on Sunday targeted senior Congress leader Sonia Gandhi for allegedly insulting 'Vande Mataram' during an Independence Day programme, demanding that she apologise to the people, even as the Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) held demonstrations across the country against the Congress.

On Sunday, complaints were filed against Sonia Gandhi and Rahul Gandhi for allegedly showing disrespect to the national song during the flag hoisting at the party headquarters a day ago.

Addressing a public meeting in Rajasthan's Chittorgarh district, Shah alleged that Sonia Gandhi asked Vande Mataram to be stopped midway during the programme.

"We all saw it on television," Shah said, adding that Sonia Gandhi should apologise to the people and to Bankim Chandra Chattopadhyay. "If there is any shame left, you should fold your hands and apologise to Bankim Babu's immortal spirit and the people," he said.

Shah remarked that opposition parties had allowed Vande Mataram to fade into oblivion out of a greed for "vote-bank politics". "The Opposition is not liking the immortal mantra and immortal song of Bankim Babu getting respect again after 80 years," Shah said. "Sonia ji, 140 crore (1.4 billion) people are watching you. The people of this country will never forgive this sin committed by you. How can anyone even dream of leaving the song of Vande Mataram incomplete?"

Several leaders of the ruling BJP also accused Sonia Gandhi of objecting to the singing of the full version of 'Vande Mataram' at the event, a charge that the Congress denied, asserting that there was no attempt to stop the singing of the full version of the national song and she was only asking for a chair for party chief Mallikarjun Kharge as he was standing for a while.

West Bengal chief minister and BJP leader Suvendu Adhikari alleged that Sonia Gandhi had objected to the singing of the complete version of the national song and said the incident had deeply offended people in the state, where Bankim Chandra is revered as "*Sahitya Samrat*". "The entire Bengal is fuming. On behalf of the people of the state, I denounce the party. I hope they will tender an unconditional apology," he said.

Shah also accused Rajasthan Congress leadership of being plagued by internal differences. "There is constant infighting within the Congress, between Ashok Gehlot, the state president and the leader of the Opposition. In the coming days, the Congress will lose its political ground in Rajasthan and will be wiped out from the state," he said.

The Union minister unveiled a slew of development projects worth ₹11,953 crore, inaugurating and laying foundation stones for works in Chittorgarh and Alwar districts. In Nimbahera, Shah also unveiled an *ashtadhatu* (eight metal) statue of former Prime Minister Atal Bihari Vajpayee before attending an event marking his death anniversary.

The controversy comes days after Parliament cleared amendments to the Prevention of Insults to National Honour Act, 1971, granting "Vande Mataram" the status at par with the national anthem.

The Congress denied the charges by the BJP, asserting that there was no attempt to stop the singing of the full version of the national song and Sonia Gandhi was only asking for a chair for party chief Mallikarjun Kharge as he was standing for a while.

The party claimed that Shah and the BJP were trying to divert attention from real issues and the "colossal failures of his and his Sahib's".

Congress's media and publicity department head Pawan Khera said when lathis rained down for chanting "Vande Mataram", it was the Congress that had sounded the bugle of freedom through this song.

Former Rajasthan chief minister Ashok Gehlot targeted the BJP and the RSS over the controversy. "How can people subscribing to the RSS ideology, who did not sing Vande Mataram due to fear of the British, talk about Vande Mataram today?" Gehlot hit back.

Rajasthan's Leader of Opposition Tikaram Jully accused police of detaining party workers who, he said, were peacefully protesting Shah's visit at the Alwar District Congress Committee office. "Has asking questions become a crime? Is peaceful protest a crime? The government cannot escape the truth by detaining those who speak out," Jully said, referring to the alleged police action against students at Jantar Mantar in Delhi.

{ VARANASI } 2 INJURED; PROBE ON

# Pistol goes off during airport security check

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**VARANASI/NEW DELHI/MUMBAI:** Two staffers at Varanasi's Lal Bahadur Shastri International Airport were injured on Sunday after a round was accidentally fired from a licensed pistol during a routine security check, officials said.

Airport director Puneet Gupta said both the injured were taken to New Lakshmi Hospital in Harhua and were stable.

The Bureau of Civil Aviation Security (BCAS), the security wing of the Union civil aviation ministry, is examining the circumstances leading to the incident, a government statement read.

According to Gupta, Kamlesh Rai, 55, along with his wife Sushma, 50, had arrived at the airport to travel to Mumbai on flight IX-1810. "He declared that he would carry his licensed weapon on the aircraft," Gupta said.

At airports, passengers carrying licensed firearms must declare the weapon at the check-in counter and complete the prescribed security formalities. If they are flying from one state to another, they must carry an All-India Permit for the firearm, which Rai had obtained. The passenger informs the airline at check-in that they are carrying a licensed firearm, after which the declaration and baggage undergo security screening.

A passenger is permitted to carry a licensed revolver, pistol or shotgun, along with the specified quantity of ammunition, in registered baggage, subject to applicable rules. The required form is completed by the passenger and verified by the airport manager.

As such passengers are screened separately from the security hold area used by other passengers, Rai was escorted to the designated screening area to complete the mandatory formalities.

Police said Central Industrial Security Force (CISF) and airline staff were checking Rai's pistol and counting its cartridges before boarding, as required under the procedure. During the process, authorised personnel from the airline concerned and AAICLAS (AAI Cargo Logistics & Allied Services Company Limited) were entering details of the passenger's registered baggage and weapon.

THE BUREAU OF CIVIL AVIATION SECURITY, UNDER MINISTRY OF CIVIL AVIATION, IS EXAMINING THE CIRCUMSTANCES LEADING TO THE INCIDENT

"The pistol's magazine was removed to record the weapon's details and the number of rounds. Preliminary investigation revealed that a round was present in the pistol's chamber and that the trigger was accidentally fired while the pistol was loaded. The discharged round reportedly ricocheted and struck [AAICLAS screeners] Suman Kumari on the leg and Rohit Raj on the toe, injuring both," the DCP's office said in a statement.

Police said an investigation was under way into the incident, including the safety protocols followed during the weapon check and the roles of the agencies involved. Further legal action will be taken based on the findings.

"The BCAS is examining the circumstances leading to the incident, including adherence to the prescribed procedures for handling and carriage of licensed weapons at airports. Appropriate action will be taken based on the findings," the civil aviation ministry said.

Rai is a former corporator of the Brihanmumbai Municipal Corporation (BMC) and leader of Shiv Sena, led by Maharashtra deputy chief minister Eknath Shinde, according to Airport Authority of India (AAI) officials in Varanasi, who spoke on condition of anonymity.

"The local police were informed immediately and the passenger has been detained for investigation and further action in accordance with law," the aviation ministry said, adding that the incident "was promptly contained and airport operations are continuing without disruption".

Based on a complaint, Phulpur police registered a case under Sections 125(a), pertaining to acts endangering the life or personal safety of others, and 125(b), pertaining to causing grievous hurt by an act endangering life or personal safety of others, of the Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita (BNS), according to a statement from the office of DCP, Gomti Zone, Neetu Kadyan.

Rai, originally from Azamgarh in Uttar Pradesh, has retained his influence in the BMC's Marol-Sahar ward in Andheri since 2002 despite switching political loyalties. He first won the BMC election from Marol-Sahar in 2002 on a Shiv Sena ticket.

Rai joined the Congress in 2007 and won again that year. After ward reservations changed in 2012, he fielded his wife, Sushma, who won the BMC election that year and again in 2017. Following the 2022 Shiv Sena split, Rai joined deputy chief minister Shinde in March 2023 and was appointed deputy leader. In the 2026 BMC election, he fielded his son, Ritesh, securing his family's hold over Ward 86 in Marol-Sahar.

In August 2025, Andheri police detained Kamlesh Rai for allegedly collecting an extortion amount of ₹5 lakh from a builder. He allegedly demanded ₹50 lakh from a builder working on a project in Andheri MIDC. After negotiations, the amount was settled at ₹35 lakh, of which ₹8 lakh was paid initially. Rai was arrested while allegedly collecting a further instalment of ₹5 lakh. Videos that surfaced after his arrest purportedly showed Rai claiming that party leaders would alert him if anyone complained against him. He was later hospitalised, citing health concerns, and granted bail.

# Rahul meets protesters, lauds courage of youth

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Rahul Gandhi

**NEW DELHI:** Leader of the Opposition in the Lok Sabha Rahul Gandhi on Sunday lauded the courage of India's youngsters who have stood firm against what the senior leader claimed Prime Minister Narendra Modi's violent regime, demanding accountability, while commending them, especially girls, who faced "the BJP (Bharatiya Janata Party) goons' misbehaviour, verbal abuse and violence."

Gandhi shared a video on social media of his interaction with students who had protested last month seeking the resignation of then education minister Dharmendra Pradhan over the issue of paper leaks and faced alleged police excesses on July 20.

In the interaction, which happened earlier this month, the Congress MP heard the students' experiences of alleged police brutality and harassment for their dissent against the government.

"I am proud of every single young person — especially the girls who faced the BJP goons' misbehaviour, verbal abuse and violence, even being forced to apologise to the prime minister," Gandhi said in the post along with the video.

One student could be heard citing police personnel as saying, "'You are all traitors'. They kept on saying that."

She recalled that she was allegedly struck seven times. She also alleged that officers had removed their nameplates and covered their faces with handkerchiefs before they baton charged at them.

Gandhi's conversation centred on letting the students recount their own experience of July 20, and much of what they described echoes claims that Delhi Police and the Centre have denied or not addressed in public.

Meanwhile, he announced that the 'Chhatron Ki Goonj' event will be held exclusively for girls in Pune on August 22. "On August 22, 'Chhatron Ki Goonj' is arriving in Pune—and this time's event will be exclusively for girls. Now the girls will speak, and the country will listen," Gandhi said.

# BJP starts youth outreach to change narrative against govt

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BJP has planned aggressive outreach targeting youth.

**NEW DELHI:** The government's proposal to offer training in artificial intelligence to 10 million people over the next year; free online coaching for competitive and government exams, and a nationwide campaign to scout and train future Olympic contenders as announced by Prime Minister Narendra Modi in his Independence Day speech, outlines the outreach the Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) has planned to reset the narrative against the party and the government, said people aware of the details.

Multiple BJP leaders said the party's internal surveys and feedback from the cadre underlined that the recent bypoll upsets and the growing criticism of the government on social media platforms are an immediate fallout of the 37-day students' protest led by the Cockroach Janta Party (CJP).

"The party has identified some gaps in our communication and outreach that could have exacerbated the students' unrest and created a perception that the concerns of the youth were not addressed... There will be more engagement with students and young adults," said a BJP lawmaker, requesting anonymity.

The party's initial response and failure to gauge the sentiments of the protesters led by the CJP has been flagged as a mis-step by a section of leaders, who believe the party should have engaged with the protesters and students at large through its youth wing, the Yuva Morcha and the students' wing of the Rashtriya Swayamsevak Sangh (RSS), the Akhil Bharatiya Vidyarthi Parishad (ABVP).

To ensure the government is not blindsided by latent anger or disappointment, particularly as preparations for polls in Punjab, Uttar Pradesh, Uttarakhand, Manipur and Goa have begun, the party has planned aggressive outreach targeting young adults.

"Going forward the Yuva Morcha will be more active, there will be more programmes and events to connect with the youth. We will also reach out to the younger lot in schools, who may be young, but are clued in and active on social media," said a second senior party functionary. "Both in Bankipur and Datia we failed to counter a particular narrative, which hurt the party... We felt some issues did not merit a response, but in hindsight we should have been more forthcoming in tackling those."

### Three students injured in Manipur's anti-census protest

**IMPHAL:** Three student protesters were injured after police used force to control a mob outside the Directorate of Census Operations in Porompat, Imphal East, on Sunday.

The protest was led by the Campaign for Just and Fair Delimitation (JFD) students' wing. Protesters raised slogans, including "No NRC, No Census", demanding that no Census activity be undertaken before the NRC is implemented in the state.

### TMC panchayat leader arrested for Cong leader's murder

**KOLKATA:** Trinamool Congress panchayat leader Fatima Bibi and two associates were arrested by police in West Bengal's Nadia district on Sunday in connection with the murder of Congress leader Anisur Rahman and his son Abu Sufian. The two were shot dead in their car on Saturday.

CM Suvendu Adhikari said, "Jabbar Sheikh got this done while sitting in jail. His wife, the TMC pradhan, has been arrested."

### Min orders steps to ensure safe drinking water at rly stations

**NEW DELHI:** Railway minister Ashwini Vaishnaw on Sunday ordered immediate corrective measures to ensure safe drinking water at railway stations, after a CAG report flagged presence of harmful bacteria in water coolers.

Vaishnaw held a daylong review and ordered several measures, including water-filtration system installation, replacement of water tanks and regular testing of water quality, a press note on Sunday said.

# J'khand govt, protesting students to hold 7th round of talks today

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Protestors burning effigies in Ranchi on Sunday. PTI

**RANCHI:** The Jharkhand government has invited job aspirants protesting alleged irregularities in state recruitment examinations for a fresh rounds of talks on Monday, officials said on Sunday.

The development comes a day after JPSC-JSSC Reforms Manch — which is spearheading the protest — announced they would gherao chief minister Hemant Soren's residence on August 20, demanding his resignation.

The decision to invite the students for the 7th round of talks came after the sub-divisional officer and additional district magistrate, law and order held a meeting with the students at the protest site in Ranchi's Jaipal Singh Munda Stadium. "The protesting students have been invited for a discussion on August 17 at 2 pm. They have been offered the option to participate in the talks accompanied by their legal advisors," the statement issued by the Ranchi district administration said.

"We will definitely go for the talks as we want to resolve the issue through dialogue. But, we are firm on two demands – a CBI probe into irregularities in recruitment tests and cancellation of the JSSC-CGL (Jharkhand Staff Selection Commission-Combine Graduate Level) exams," Manch leader Ravindra Paswan said.

Meanwhile, on the 23rd day of the stir on Sunday, protesting students burnt effigies of chief minister Hemant Soren, Congress leader Rahul Gandhi, and RJD leader Tejashwi Yadav in Ranchi's Albert Ekka Chowk, alleging that their "demands continue to fall on deaf ears".

The protesters expressed anger over the "administrative misconduct" directed at fasting student leader Devendra Nath Mahto on August 15, who was allegedly physically prevented by the police from leaving Sadar Hospital to participate in an Independence Day Tiranga Yatra. The action triggered widespread outrage, prompting four more people to join the indefinite hunger strike.

On Mahto being restrained, Ranchi deputy commissioner Manju Nath Bhajantri said, "Hospital administration refused to grant him permission due to his critical health condition and physical weakness."

State Congress' media in-charge Rakesh Sinha said that the state unit will hold a meeting on August 18 to discuss reforms in the examinations and that the party will "strongly raise the students' voice".

# Delhi-based NGO under scrutiny in probe into poaching of 10 leopards

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**BHOPAL:** The Madhya Pradesh State Tiger Strike Force (STSF) has summoned the CEO of Delhi-based NGO, Wildlife SOS, for questioning over its alleged involvement in an inter-state poaching racket, officials aware of the matter said on Sunday.

The NGO has been working with the Madhya Pradesh government since 2006, including the current rehabilitation project of a sloth bear at Van Vihar National Park in Bhopal.

Wildlife SOS CEO Kartick Satyanarayan did not respond to calls, emails, or messages on social media platforms until late on Sunday night.

The action follows the seizure of ten leopard skins in Agra on July 23 by the Uttar Pradesh forest department, which also arrested several smugglers. Subsequent raids in Sheopur and Morena districts in Madhya Pradesh led to the arrest of seven more alleged poachers and recovery of leopard body parts, skeletons, and leg-hold traps, the officials said.

According to officials, the accused from MP — all tribals from Sheopur, confessed to poaching ten leopards from Kuno Wildlife division, Sheopur forest division, and Chambal Sanctuary.

Based on scientific evidence, two more suspects were arrested in Delhi last week by a joint team of STSF and the Wildlife Crime Control Bureau (WCCB), Officials, however, identified only one of the two accused from Delhi, as Waseem Akram. They said Akram was an employee of Wildlife SOS.

Additional principal chief conservator of forests (Wildlife) L Krishnamurthy said, "Madhya Pradesh is conducting continuous operations under the special campaign against inter-state poaching gangs. Wildlife SOS is a prestigious NGO, and we have strong evidence of its alleged involvement. The backward linkages (suppliers) have been established, forward linkages (buyers) are still under investigation."

He added, "While probing the forward linkages, accused Waseem Akram was arrested on August 13. We are currently interrogating him."

An MP forest department official, who asked not to be named, said, "The interrogation of Akram has revealed that the NGO members, the accused arrested from Sheopur and Morena, and members of an ironsmith community from Haryana were part of a WhatsApp group on which discussions were held on poaching and metal traps. The CEO of Wildlife SOS has been summoned to record their statement."

The official, however, said it was yet to be ascertained if the group was directly involved in wildlife trafficking.

Wildlife activist Ajay Dubey demanded a high-level inquiry. "If ten leopards were poached in Kuno, what is the guarantee that cheetahs were not targeted?" he asked.

## CJP WORKER'S FATHER KILLED IN BENGAL, 3 HELD

**KOLKATA:** West Bengal chief minister Suvendu Adhikari said on Sunday that police had arrested three of the five people accused in the assault and killing of the father of a Cockroach Janta Party (CJP) activist in Bakura district, even as the CJP demanded their arrest, alleging they were BJP workers.

Adhikari denied that the accused were BJP workers, adding that they were described to be miscreants. "I am also the home minister. It is our duty to maintain law and order. Three of the five accused have been arrested. But complaint did not refer to them as BJP workers. It said they were miscreants," he said at a press conference.

In an X post on Sunday, CJP founder and national convenor Abhijeet Dipke said Sk Muhammad Mafik, the deceased, and his son, CJP volunteer Shaik Abdul Hafeez, were assaulted on Thursday after Hafeez raised concerns about a primary school at Karisunda in the Indus community development block as part of CJP's 'School Thik Karo' campaign. HTC

{ RAYAGADA DISTRICT }

# Odisha tribals fight to preserve their mother tongues

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In the Engerba school, teachers now conduct examinations in Saora and the Sorang Sompeng script. HT

**BHUBANESWAR:** In Odisha's Rayagada district, 14 Saora tribal families in Engerba village are fighting to save their mother tongue from extinction, offering rice or pulses as meals to teachers and students as an incentive.

The families contribute food grains to the SP Mangali Ashram school, where 62 students from Classes I to VIII learn in Saora and study the indigenous Sorang Sompeng script.

The villagers established the school after realising that Saora children were gradually losing their language and traditional script amid the dominance of state languages in formal education. They pooled their savings, built a mud structure and began teaching children in Saora.

"The idea was to ensure children learnt their mother tongue and Sorang Sompeng script before moving to higher classes, where instruction was more likely to be in Odia or English," said Chakrapani Sabara, a retired government official who took over the school's administration after its founder, Giria Sabar, died over a decade ago.

"In the Engerba school, teachers now conduct examinations in Saora and the Sorang Sompeng script. Textbooks are translated into Saora before being taught, while material available in Odia or English is transcribed into the Sorang Sompeng script and explained to students. When these children move on to high school or college, they would have already retained their language and learnt the script," Sabara said.

### A wider struggle

The initiative reflects a wider struggle across Odisha, where nearly 10 million tribals from 64 communities speak 21 distinct tribal languages and 74 dialects. Younger generations, however, are forgetting their native tongues and, with them, an intrinsic part of their identity.

Some communities are documenting oral histories and songs; others are developing teaching materials and scripts to prevent their languages from disappearing. The state government adopted a multilingual education programme in 2006, under which tribal children were taught in their mother tongue during the first five years of primary education.

UNESCO considers languages spoken by fewer than 10,000 people potentially endangered. As many as 197 Indian tribal languages have been classified as endangered.

Only Santhali, Ho, Sora and Kui have their own scripts. While Santhali is included in the Eighth Schedule of the Constitution, efforts are underway to secure similar recognition for Ho.

### Keeping languages alive

Language researcher Gobardhan Panda has spent four decades documenting Remosam, spoken by the Bonda tribe, one of the Particularly Vulnerable Tribal Groups in Malkangiri district.

UNESCO classifies Remosam as severely endangered, with only an estimated 6,500 to 7,000 fluent speakers, mainly in the Upper Bonda hills.

Panda, who has worked in the Bonda Hills since 1982, has written a book, 'Remosam, Manisha bhasha'. "I started speaking with them in Remosam within six months of living there and I promised the Bondas that as long as I am alive, I would speak to them in their language....I tell them whatever happens, never forget your language. It is your priceless heritage," said Panda.

In the same district, three Didayi farmers have begun recording forgotten words, folk stories and festival songs in Gta Asa, the Didayi language, which has no written script. In Sundargarh, the Oraon community holds weekly meetings where elders encourage younger members to converse in Kurux.

At Engerba, the school continues without government support. Its 14 teachers, some graduates and B.Ed degree holders, receive no salary and share meals with students. Villagers have also agreed to contribute from their wages earned on road construction.

"The arrangements are surely modest but I am happy that the community has kept a language and a script alive for more than two decades," said Sabara.

# The trouble with roundabouts

Once symbolising India's best-planned cities, roundabouts are today emerging as major traffic bottlenecks

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Teen Murti was identified as the worst affected roundabout in the NDMC area this year. ARVIND YADAV/HT

**NEW DELHI:** Every weekday morning, Rishi Kumar finds himself caught in what he calls 'a slow-motion whirlpool of traffic' on his way to the office in central Delhi. "These roundabouts in Lutyens' Delhi really test my patience and my driving skills, and cause unexpected delays in reaching office," he says.

"They are beautiful, but they are also big traffic bottlenecks now."

Kumar's frustration is shared by millions of commuters who find it hard to tackle the increasingly gridlocked roundabouts across Indian cities, where cars and auto rickshaws cut diagonally across lanes, two-wheelers try to squeeze between buses, and vehicles entering the circle keep pushing forward until those already inside are forced to brake.

The basic rule of a roundabout—that the traffic already inside the circle gets the right of way—is reduced to a free-for-all, and within minutes the whole junction locks up.

It was not always so. Roundabouts once symbolised a grand idea in Indian urban planning. Edwin Lutyens used them to anchor New Delhi's grand avenues, Le Corbusier built them into the ordered road hierarchy of Chandigarh, and H. K. Mewada and Prakash M. Apte integrated them into Gandhinagar's low-density, tree-lined grid.

The roundabouts ensured smooth movement through a city, slowed vehicles without traffic lights, and gave these cities a unique identity.

When these circular junctions were laid out decades ago, private vehicle ownership was nowhere near today's levels, and roads carried buses, bicycles, and a modest number of cars.

Last year, a survey of 39 roundabouts by traffic police in the New Delhi Municipal Council (NDMC) area found that disproportionate road widths, misaligned footpaths, oversized plantation spaces, and narrow roundabout diameters were squeezing traffic flow and creating bottlenecks at these colonial-era circles.

Five roundabouts were identified as the worst affected: Teen Murti Haifa, Tughlak Road, Sunehri Bagh, Jaswant Singh (Panchmukhi Chowk), and Q-Point near India Gate.

When a roundabout gridlocks, geometry usually takes the blame, but experts say the real issue is broader: Cities have grown faster than these junctions were built to handle, and the resulting chaos is driven by a mix of urban growth, road design, driving behaviour, and surrounding network traffic

Architect Goonmeet Singh Chauhan, who has worked on several public projects in Delhi, argues that roundabouts remain "among the most effective intersection types for cities, but says, "The problem is many of them have not evolved in accordance with changing traffic volume and pattern".

Dikshu Kukreja, architect and urbanist, has a different perspective. "Roundabouts have unfortunately become an easy target in discussions around congestion, but I believe the issue is more nuanced," he says.

As cities grow, he argues, some junctions will need redesigning for higher volumes and safety, but in heritage precincts the goal should be retaining spatial character while selectively improving geometry, visibility, and lane organisation.

"Urban identity and efficient mobility are not mutually exclusive when design is informed by evidence," adds Kukreja.

### More than a design issue

Architect Mitu Mathur points out that the transformation of the surrounding city lies at the heart of the problem.

Chandigarh's roundabouts, she says, need to be understood within Le Corbusier's larger planning vision, built around a clear hierarchy of movement, sector planning, and a structured relationship between built form and landscape.

"The challenge today is that these junctions are now operating in a very different urban context than the one they were designed for."

If Mathur points to changing urban form, Sewa Ram, professor of transport planning at the School of Planning and Architecture (SPA), Delhi, argues that driver behaviour is equally important.

"People don't understand the difference between a roundabout and a rotary," he explains. In a roundabout, he says, vehicles yield to traffic already inside and wait before merging; in a rotary, entering and circulating vehicles weave together before splitting toward their exits.

"Most of the roundabouts in Lutyens' Delhi were originally designed as roundabouts, but because nobody follows the yield rule and nobody even knows whose right of way it is, they end up functioning like rotaries instead. That is one of the important reasons behind the chaos," says Ram.

A congested junction, he points out, is not an isolated problem.

"Instead of looking at a single roundabout in isolation, there is a need to look at the entire network. You have to treat the area as one complete circulation plan, not fix one junction and hope it functions well," he says.

At Teen Murti, he points out, heavy traffic converges from Akbar Road, Safdarjung Road, and the other three arms feeding the roundabout, and it doesn't have the capacity to handle it; so some of that traffic needs to be diverted elsewhere. "But if a junction is carrying more than 10,000 passenger car units an hour at peak time, it has gone beyond its design capacity," he says.

### A different way forward

Many cities such as Ahmedabad and Chennai are now redesigning their intersections, the former in collaboration with Sardar Vallabhbhai National Institute of Technology (SVNIT) Surat, using traffic simulations and peak passenger car unit analysis.

Chennai, meanwhile, is redesigning junctions with wider bell mouths and better road geometry to smooth traffic flow and improve pedestrian safety.

Ahmedabad now uses three models depending on volume: high-volume junctions become conventional signalised crossings, intermediate-volume ones keep their roundabout shape but add synchronised signals, and low-volume junctions stay signal-free.

These intersections are evaluated using Level of Service (LOS) framework, says Gaurang Joshi, professor, transportation systems at SVNIT Surat.

The scale ranges from LOS-A, representing free-flowing traffic, to LOS-F, where traffic movement completely breaks down.

"Instead of demolishing junctions entirely, we have reduced the radius of central islands, widened circulating lanes, recalculated signal timings, and eliminated minor service roads feeding into congested circles," adds Joshi. "Traffic studies show that these targeted redesigns have reduced average delay times by nearly 40%."

Shreya Gadepalli, an urban mobility expert, says a well-designed roundabout can move more traffic than a signal. At a typical four-arm signalised junction, she points out, drivers spend roughly three-quarters of the cycle waiting at a red light, since only one approach gets a green at any given moment.

"So the efficiency is much lower than a roundabout, which is effectively always green. It might look slower-moving, but it's actually moving constantly," she says.

That advantage, however, comes with a trade-off.

"Roundabouts are not pedestrian-friendly because traffic almost never stops, and so crossing on foot usually means watching for gaps and making a dangerous run for it," she adds.

### The Chandigarh lessons

In Chandigarh, the conflict between preserving urban design and managing traffic has come a full circle. Seeking to unclog arterial routes, city officials removed several of its iconic Le Corbusier-designed key roundabouts in favour of signalised intersections.

The experiment backfired: free-flowing signalised junctions encouraged speeding and red-light jumping, triggering a sharp rise in high-impact collisions.

Recognising that circular rotaries naturally force drivers to decelerate, the administration reversed course. It has since begun converting major signalised junctions back into rotaries, including along Vikas and Madhya Margs, halting any further removal of the city's signature traffic circles.

Even in heritage precincts, experts argue that major gains are often possible without altering the roundabout itself.

Joshi points out, restricting one minor movement can reduce congestion substantially, without touching the circle itself.

"We've implemented this successfully at two locations in Ahmedabad," he says, citing cases where banning a difficult right turn and rerouting to a downstream U-turn cleared congestion while leaving the circle intact."

Central islands in cities like Delhi, Gurugram, and Coimbatore have also turned into spaces for installing sculptures, commercial advertising or dense foliage, blocking the sightlines drivers need to navigate safely.

That raises a broader question: have roundabouts gradually become civic showpieces at the expense of their primary traffic function?

"Green landscapes, public art, and visual identity add significant value to the urban experience. A successful junction is one that balances mobility, safety, and the public realm, rather than optimising only for vehicles," says Chauhan.

"The concern arises when the visual prominence of an element begins to affect the junction's basic functioning. But the larger issue is the absence of an integrated approach, where urban design and traffic engineering inform each other from the beginning," says Mathur.

Gadepalli's makes a broader point. "We need to understand that it is also a mobility crisis, not just a design problem," she says.

Expanding public transport, higher parking fees and introducing congestion pricing to divert through-traffic away from city centres can help reduce peak volumes on roundabouts in places like Lutyens' Delhi.

"Even a 10 to 15% reduction in traffic can dramatically improve network performance," she says.

# Murder-suicide: Navy sailor, wife, kids found dead

INVESTIGATORS SUSPECT THAT THE DEATHS WERE LIKELY LINKED TO A DISPUTE BETWEEN THE NAVY SAILOR AND HIS WIFE

**Megha Sood**
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**MUMBAI:** A 30-year-old Indian Navy sailor, his wife and their two children — a three-year-old son and a two-month-old daughter — were found dead in his official residence at Navy Nagar in south Mumbai, police said on Sunday, suspecting it to be a case of murder and suicide.

Deputy commissioner of police Maneesh Kalwaniya said the sailor allegedly died by suicide while his 28-year-old wife and their children died due to poisoning at their residence in Cuffe Parade on Saturday.

"The exact cause of death can only be determined after detailed forensic and post-mortem reports are received," Kalwaniya said.

Officers aware of the matter at the Cuffe Parade police station said the deaths were likely linked to a dispute between the sailor and his wife, with investigators suspecting that an altercation occurred between them before the incident. "We are attempting to put together the exact sequence of events preceding the deaths," a police officer said, requesting anonymity.

According to the police, the family hailed from Rajasthan and the couple was married for four years. Around 8pm on Saturday, the police control room received a call from their neighbours, saying the main door to the family's residence was ajar and the family members were probably dead.

"When a police team visited the sailor's residence, they found his body while his wife and two kids were lying unconscious on the bed," the police officer cited above said.

A team from the Forensic Science Laboratory (FSL) also inspected the residence and collected evidence, although no suicide note was found in the premises, the officer added.

The police rushed all of them to the JJ Hospital, where they were declared brought dead. Accordingly, the police registered an accidental death report (ADR). The deceased sailor's younger brother, who also serves in the navy, claimed the bodies of his family members from JJ Hospital.

The Indian Navy has confirmed full cooperation with civil law enforcement agencies to ensure a thorough investigation into the matter.

"In an unfortunate incident at Navy Nagar, Colaba, an Indian Navy sailor along with his wife and two children have been found dead at their residence. Investigation is in progress by the police, and the Indian Navy is extending all possible assistance," the Indian Navy said in an official statement.

# India to host BRICS environment working group meeting today

**Jasjeev Gandhiok**
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**NEW DELHI:** India will host BRICS Environment Working Group meetings in the national capital from August 17 to 18 at Bharat Mandapam under the overarching theme India's 2026 chairship, 'Building for Resilience, Innovation, Cooperation and Sustainability', the environment ministry said on Sunday.

The ministry said the BRICS Senior Officers' Meeting of the Environment Working Group (EWG) and the Contact Group on Climate Change and Sustainable Development will hold meetings on Monday, while Tuesday will see Delhi hosting the 12th BRICS Environment Ministers' Meeting.

The BRICS Environment Ministers' Meeting will be presided over by Union environment minister Bhupender Yadav and aims to provide a platform for ministers, senior officers, policymakers and experts from the member countries to engage in substantive discussions, foster consensus and strengthen environmental cooperation.

The BRICS Environment Working Group (EWG) was established in 2015 to address fundamental environment priorities, exchange experiences, share best practices and strengthen collective action among BRICS Member Countries. The Contact Group on Climate Change and Sustainable Development was established in 2024 as an effective mechanism for cooperation on climate change issues among member countries.

Officials said the Senior Officers' Meeting would include an inaugural session and deliberations on the priorities of the BRICS Environment Working Group and Contact Group on Climate Change and Sustainable Development.

"As part of the Chairship, India has identified four priority areas for focused engagements under the BRICS Environment Working Group," said the ministry in a statement. The ministry also said it has already initiated discussions and deliberations through a series of virtual meetings, technical sessions, webinars and dialogues between March and July 2026.

## 2 MINORS AMONG 4 HELD FOR RAPE OF TRIPURA GIRL

**Priyanka Deb Barman**
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**AGARTALA:** Tripura police arrested two persons and apprehended four minors for gangraping a teenage girl at a village in Gomati district, police said on Sunday.

"Both adult accused are now in judicial custody. As the minors cannot be arrested, they were apprehended and sent to a juvenile home. We are investigating the matter," said a police officer. Police said that the incident occurred on August 1 when the rape-survivor (aged above 16) was going home alone and the accused, who were standing on the road then, forcibly took her to a forest and allegedly gangraped her.

Her family filed a complaint with the police on August 14. Based on this complaint, police lodged a case, arrested the two adult accused persons and apprehended the four minors who are aged between 16 and 17 years, police said. The accused persons were residents of a nearby village, police added.

{ HANUR FIRING } CM SEEKS PROBE

## Vijay condemns killing of 3 Tamils in K'taka

**HTC and Agencies**
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C Joseph Vijay

**CHENNAI/BENGALURU:** Tamil Nadu chief minister C Joseph Vijay on Sunday strongly condemned the killing of three Tamils who were allegedly suspected to be poachers by Karnataka forest department officials, calling the department's explanation of the incident "unacceptable".

In a post on X, the official handle of Vijay's Tamilaga Vettri Kazhagam (TVK) shared his statement, in which he said the three men were shot dead in the Cauvery Wildlife Sanctuary area in Karnataka.

"It is heartbreaking that Anthony Sami, John Rose Peter, and Kumar, who were Tamils residing in villages in the Hanur taluk of Chamarajanagar district in Karnataka, were shot dead by Karnataka Forest Department officials in the early hours of August 15, 2026, in the Cauvery Wildlife Sanctuary area. I strongly condemn this massacre," the post said.

Vijay said the circumstances surrounding the deaths required a thorough and impartial investigation, and criticised the explanation given by the Karnataka forest department. "...I strongly urge the Karnataka government to take appropriate measures to ensure that no such incident occurs again," Vijay added.

Meanwhile, families of the three men, who were killed in an alleged exchange of fire with forest department personnel on August 15, protested in Hanur, demanding compensation, government jobs for the dependants.

# ED writes to Punjab DGP, seeks FIR against man linked to Mann's OSD

**Ravinder Vasudeva**
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**CHANDIGARH:** The Punjab government is examining the Enforcement Directorate's (ED) allegations against private person Nitin Gohal and others for allegedly colluding with the officer on special duty (OSD) to chief minister Bhagwant Mann to illegally influence various government functioning.

In ED's letter to the Punjab director general of police (DGP), accessed by HT, the federal agency has alleged that Gohal acted as an intermediary between interested persons and Rajbir Ghuman, OSD to CM Mann, and was involved in influencing transfers and postings of government officials, leaking confidential government documents, facilitating arms licences and securing government approvals in lieu of alleged monetary and other benefits.

The communication, sent under Section 66 (2) of PMLA, has put the state government in a bind as the agency has sought registration of a "confidential FIR" against Gohal and others based on material gathered during its investigation.

In exchange, Gohal, in coordination with associates Ghuman, Bir Devinder, Jitin Gohal, alias Raja, collected proceeds of crime to the tune of crores in the form of cash, land and kind, according to ED communication. The ED had also claimed to have seized ₹1 crore in cash and recovered a bag containing ₹20 lakh that was allegedly thrown from a flat in a private society in Kharar owned by Gohal.

While DGP Gaurav Yadav did not respond to HT's message for his comment, Gohal termed ED's allegations "false propaganda to implicate Ghuman".

"Rajbir is my old friend and I have been assisting him in his office as OSD to the chief minister as a personal assistant. ED is distorting administrative chats. If they had evidence, they would have booked me. But they have failed to establish my role in any fraud," he said.

The August 11 letter also sparked political furore, lending a potent issue to the opposition parties to target the AAP government in the run up to the assembly elections due early next year.

## 7 HELD IN K'TAKA FOR GANG RAPE OF MENTALLY ILL

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**GADAG:** Karnataka police have arrested four people for repeatedly raping a 26-year-old woman with mental disabilities and apprehended three others, including a rural medical practitioner (RMP) doctor and a staff nurse, for forcing her to undergo an illegal abortion of her three-month pregnancy in Gadag, officers said on Sunday.

All seven accused were arrested on Friday, produced before the court and remanded in judicial custody, police added.

Gadag district superintendent of police (SP) Rohan Jagadeesh told reporters that while the first four accused sexually assaulted her repeatedly, the remaining three forced-fed the woman 10 abortion pills and carried out an illegal termination of her three-month pregnancy. The accused were Sikandar Bepari, Shabirahmad Junasab, Pradeep Navalekar, Bharat Koravar, Sandeep Navalekar, Dr Nagaraj Kamtar, an RMP doctor from Bellatti and Rekha Shirahatti, a staff nurse at Shigli Government Hospital.

# Odisha on flood alert as heavy rain looms

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Three trucks lie overturned in a ditch due to heavy rains in Kendrapara on Sunday.

**BHUBANESWAR:** Odisha is bracing for another potentially devastating flood on Monday as a fresh low-pressure area formed over the Bay of Bengal, with about 515,000 people in six districts already affected and the India Meteorological Department (IMD) issuing a red warning for extremely heavy rain in Balasore, Keonjhar, Bhadrak and Mayurbhanj districts.

Chief secretary Anu Garg reviewed the situation on Sunday and held discussions with collectors of affected districts to assess relief and rescue operations. Odisha has received 953 mm of rainfall between June 1 and August 16, about 27% above normal, she said. Flooding has affected 49 blocks, five urban areas and 331 gram panchayats, while 237,000 people have been evacuated and 293 relief camps opened.

Meanwhile, IMD forecast heavy rain across Odisha from August 16 to 18, with rainfall expected to intensify on August 17, particularly in northern districts such as Balasore and Mayurbhanj, where it could exceed 20 cm in 24 hours. IMD regional director Manorama Mohanty said the fresh low-pressure area had formed over northwest and adjoining West Bengal-North Odisha coasts and was likely to move northwestwards and become more marked over the next 24 hours. Fishermen were advised not to venture into the sea during the period.

The fresh weather forecast has added to the woes of districts already battling floods caused by the Baitarani, Brahmani, Salandi, Jalaka and Budhabalanga rivers. The situation remained grim in Balasore, Bhadrak, Jajpur, Mayurbhanj and Keonjhar, where about 270,000 people had been affected.

## SEARCH ON FOR TWO WORKERS IN CHAMOLI TUNNEL

**DEHRADUN:** Rescue workers continued searching for two workers missing from an inundated tunnel in Chamoli, Uttarakhand, on Sunday, officials familiar with the matter said, adding that efforts were also underway to pump out water, clear debris and remove machinery trapped inside the tunnel for a thorough search of the affected site.

A suspected aquifer burst pushed a rush of water and debris through the under-construction Hydro Development Corporation (THDC) tunnel in Pipalkoti on Thursday, trapping 22 workers who were on shift when the incident occurred around 7 pm. Of them, eight have been declared dead, and 11 are in hospital with injuries.

Chamoli district magistrate Gaurav Kumar said, "Teams from various agencies are carrying out an intensive search operation on a war footing to trace the two missing workers. Water is being continuously pumped out of the tunnel to bring down the water level and facilitate the movement of rescue teams into the affected sections." "Rescue teams are also prioritising the removal of machinery and other heavy obstructions trapped inside the tunnel."

"Every possible location inside the tunnel is being identified and searched. No possible location is being left unchecked, and all available resources are being," he said. HTC

# Tribunals can order eviction of others to protect elderly: SC

**Utkarsh Anand**
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The apex court set aside Allahabad high court orders.

**NEW DELHI:** The Supreme Court has ruled that tribunals constituted under the Maintenance and Welfare of Parents and Senior Citizens Act, 2007 have the power to order eviction of persons from a property when such a measure is necessary to ensure the senior citizen's maintenance or protection.

A bench of justices PS Narasimha and Alok Aradhe said that the legislation was intended to ensure that advancing age does not become synonymous with "neglect, insecurity, or indignity" and reflects values deeply rooted in the country's civilisational ethos, which "revere the mother and the father as divine."

It emphasised that the measure of a civilised society is often reflected in the dignity, respect and security it affords to its elderly. "Across cultures, religions, and civilisations, senior citizens have been regarded not merely as dependents requiring care, but as repositories of wisdom, experience, and collective memory whose guidance enriches families and society alike," said the bench.

It added that the fundamental right provisions relating to life, dignity and equality envisage a social order that protects the vulnerable and enables every individual to live with dignity throughout the course of life and that "this commitment finds statutory expression in the Act."

The court said the power to order eviction flows from the statutory scheme itself. While Section 7 provides for constitution of tribunals and Section 8 empowers them to conduct inquiries through a summary procedure with powers of a civil court, Section 27 expressly bars the jurisdiction of civil courts. "On this analogy, we have no hesitation in holding that the tribunal under the Act has power to order eviction in order to ensure the maintenance or protection of a senior citizen," the bench held in a recent order.

The judgment came in an appeal filed by Ravi Kant Gupta, whose 81-year-old mother had been forced to leave his residential premises and reside in an old-age facility. Gupta had approached the district magistrate seeking eviction of his son from the property, alleging that his son did not permit his grandmother to stay in the house and had created nuisance.

The sub-divisional magistrate ordered the son's eviction in November 2022, holding that the premises was Gupta's self-acquired property. The district magistrate upheld the order and directed the son and his wife to hand over possession of the premises. The Allahabad High Court, however, subsequently quashed the eviction orders, holding that authorities under the 2007 Act did not have the power to order eviction. It reiterated the view while dismissing Gupta's review petition in January 2024.

The Supreme Court set aside both high court orders and restored the eviction orders passed by the authorities under the Act.

The bench emphasised that the Act has to be understood in the context of the constitutional commitment to protect vulnerable persons and enable every individual to live with dignity. It referred to Articles 21 and 41 of the Constitution and said Parliament had enacted the law to provide a speedy remedy to senior citizens.

The court also relied on earlier judgments, including the three-judge bench ruling in S Vanitha Vs Deputy Commissioner (2021), to hold that eviction may be ordered where it is necessary and expedient to ensure the maintenance and protection of a senior citizen or parent. It noted that subsequent two-judge benches had reiterated the same position.

## BSF JAWAN HELD FOR BEATING WIFE TO DEATH IN PB

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**HOSHIARPUR:** A Border Security Force (BSF) jawan was arrested for allegedly beating his wife to death in a suspected case of domestic violence in Punjab's Hoshiarpur district and trying to pass it off as a fall from the roof, police said on Sunday.

According to police, the accused, Amarjit Singh, had recently been posted in Kashmir and was currently on leave before joining.

Sing and his wife, Rama, had been married for 12 years and had two children.

Police said they were alerted by Rama's father Ram Chand, who alleged that Amarjit had beaten her to death in the Badhalian village, as her body bore multiple injury marks. He alleged that Amarjit was an alcoholic, who often subjected his daughter to physical abuse.

Police cited the father as saying that they received a call from Amarjit on August 14, informing that Rama had accidentally fallen off their roof and had been hospitalised. When the family reached the hospital, they found that Rama was dead.

Ram Chand alleged that one of Amarjit's uncles and his wife were also involved in the murder and cover-up of the incident.

Acting on his complaint, Hajipur police booked Amarjit for murder and arrested him.

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## CENSUS 2027

located...Even if there is one family in a remote village atop a difficult terrain, our officials will go and record their data," said Sharma.

The directorate of census operations hopes to first record the data of lieutenant governor VK Saxena, MP Hanifa Jan, chairman of the Kargil hill development council Mohhamad Jaffer Akhoon and chief secretary Ashish Kundra on Monday morning.

"The people of Ladakh are very enthusiastic ...the census gives us requisite parameters of development and socio-economic growth. We get an overall view for futuristic planning," said Akhoon.

In Himachal Pradesh, the exercise will cover three districts, including Komik, one of the world's highest motorable villages at an elevation of 15,049 feet in the Spiti valley. With 130 people in 2011, the village is home to the 500 year-old Lundup Tsemo Gompa Buddhist Monastery.

"Census 2027 will be the 16th census of India and the eighth after Independence. For the first time, citizens will have the option of participating through a self-enumeration facility," said principal census officer and director of census operations Deep Shikha Sharma.

"For this around 6,903 snow-bound villages and areas of Himachal Pradesh have been identified for advance enumeration due to harsh winter conditions that make access difficult during the regular census period...the reason is Himachal's difficult winter conditions as snow-bound villages and areas where heavy snowfall can make travel and access difficult during the winter months. Therefore, population enumeration in these areas will be completed before the onset of severe winter," added Deep Shikha Sharma.

The census reference date for these areas is October 1, 2026. The early census is particularly important for remote areas such as Kinnaur, Lahaul-Spiti and Pangi-Bharmour in Chamba.

Deep Shikha Sharma said that the census data will be collected through dual mode through an app, named Census 2027-PE, and through self enumeration. Residents can complete the census online through the official self-enumeration portal from August 17 to August 31, 2026, after which they will receive a self-enumeration ID that can be shared with census officials during field verification. Sharma clarified that no OTP will be asked during the census process.

To conduct the exercise, around 20,390 enumerators and supervisors will be deployed across Himachal Pradesh. Officials said the digital census will be supported by the mobile application and a dedicated census management and monitoring portal, enabling real-time monitoring of field operations. The mobile application will function in both online and offline modes, ensuring smooth data collection even in remote and network-deficient areas. "So, Himachal's early census is primarily a weather and accessibility-driven exercise, aimed at reaching remote communities before winter makes these areas difficult to access," she said.

In Uttarakhand, the exercise will cover around 52,000 people across 131 villages and three towns in four districts – 69 villages in Uttarkashi, 23 in Chamoli, four in Rudraprayag and 35 in Pithoragarh. The three towns are Gangotri, Badrinath and Kedarnath. "Compared to other hill states, Uttarakhand has a relatively small snow-bound area," said Eva Srivastava, director of census operations, Uttarakhand.

"Our preparations are underway for population enumeration in snow-bound areas. We have completed training for master and field trainers. Training for charge officers is underway, followed by training for enumerators and supervisors," Srivastava said. Around 162 enumerators and 34 supervisors are expected to be deployed for the exercise in the snow-bound areas. A simultaneous population enumeration of military and paramilitary units in snow bound areas will also be conducted during the period. Nodal officers for the same are being appointed at the state level, while special charge officers will be notified by the respective units. Enumerators and supervisors will then be appointed for the exercise.

"Because of security reasons, the enumeration for military and paramilitary units will be carried out in paper mode. The data will subsequently be entered digitally at the offices of the special charge officers," Srivastava said.

Last week, the Union government notified 40 questions, including a query on caste for the first time in independent India, to be asked of respondents. The order from Registrar General of India Mrityunjay Kumar Narayan notified 11 questions more than the 2011 Census, the last time the exercise was conducted in India. Among the new questions were those asking for parental details, and others on passports, Aadhaar, Voter ID and mobile number, driving licence, and Covid-19 vaccination details, and permanent residential address — which raised privacy concerns.

The question on caste was listed as question number 10 in the notification — as "scheduled caste/scheduled tribe/caste" — in open ended format, which means Census officers will record the caste of a person as declared, without any requirement to match it to pre-prepared lists.

An officer said the self-enumeration was part of the digital transformation of the census and allowed residents to enter details of members of their household online before an enumerator visits them. "It is intended to reduce the time required for the door-to-door exercise and improve the efficiency of data collection," he said. In the first phase - houselisting and housing data collection - too, the self-enumeration facility was given to all the residents.

Originally scheduled for 2021, the census was initially postponed due to the Covid-19 pandemic. Data collection is targeted to conclude by March 1, 2027, but officials say the collation and publication of results will take two to three years. The exercise is likely to stamp India's status as the world's most-populous nation.

"Once the entire exercise is over next year, we will have the first comprehensive population data in more than a decade, including detailed information on caste, education, employment, migration and other socio-economic characteristics of India's population," said a second government official.

## TMC LEADER FOUND DEAD

bhum district. The BJP has alleged corruption and irregularities in the authority, including in connection with sand tenders. To be sure, it did not specifically target Banerjee, who served as the body's chairman from 2016 to 2026.

District police superintendent Vidit Raj Bhundesh said no FIR has been registered over the allegations nor a formal complaint was received so far. Leaders from across parties called for a probe into the incident, with former chief minister Mamata Banerjee-led TMC accusing the state's ruling BJP of systematically vilifying Banerjee. The BJP and the rival Ritabrata Banerjee-led TMC faction, however, accused "corrupt" TMC leaders of threatening him.

"The harassment and mental pressure he faced, despite his long record of public service, should make all of us pause and reflect on the human cost of relentless political hostility," Mamata posted on X.

TMC national general secretary Abhishek Banerjee said the 75-year-old was a victim of a relentless smear campaign. "Those who participated in this smear campaign should reflect on the human consequences of their words and actions. Political battles will come and go, but a life once lost can never be brought back," he posted on X.

Once among Mamata Banerjee's close associates, Banerjee had distanced himself from her after his defeat in the recent state polls, people aware of the matter said. In June, he stepped down as TMC Birbhum district president but said he would remain a member of the party. On June 22, he attended a meeting of rebel TMC MLAs but was not seen at any other meeting of the camp after that.

Chief minister Suvendu Adhikari dismissed the allegation that Banerjee was under corruption scanner. "No case was registered against him and he was never sent any notice by the police. It is possible that corrupt people in the TMC might have threatened him, saying they would take his name if there was a probe... After all, he had distanced himself from the Mamata faction of the TMC. Call records should be examined," Adhikari said. He added that the police will also examine the veracity of the purported suicide note.

West Bengal's Leader of Opposition Ritabrata said that many innocent workers and leaders in TMC were forced to bear the consequences of the corruption and "legal mistakes" committed by a handful of people in the party.

"For the last 15 years, organised loot and legal mistakes have taken place in the state. Though only a handful of people in the TMC were involved, innocent politicians had to bear the responsibility. They were insulted in their areas," he said in a video message.

A TMC veteran, Banerjee also worked as an associate lecturer of Bengali at Rampurhat College. He won the Rampurhat assembly seat five times in a row from 2001 before losing to the BJP's Dhruba Saha this year. "I sought his blessings after winning the seat," Saha said.

Banerjee's brother Prashanta said the veteran leader spent Saturday night chatting normally with family members until around midnight. "We ate together... I was among those who first spotted him inside the party office," he said.

## DELHI MASTER PLAN

receive urban services from the beginning," says the plan, which the Delhi Development Authority (DDA) approved last week.

That clause essentially looks to plug a glaring gap in DDA's efforts to expand the city – its housing projects in Narela and Bawana met with tepid responses, with buyers and residents complaining of a severe lack of essential infrastructure.

Experts pointed out that building these services were crucial

"Authorities need to keep in mind challenges related to water quality, security, ensuring adequate greening and public space network for reducing urban heat effect; priority for pedestrians and non-motorised transport users while developing road infrastructure and grounded measures towards better air quality. Vertical growth is only possible if civic infrastructure is also accordingly developed," said Prerna Mehta, associate director, urban development, WRI India.

The plan identifies Delhi's ageing planned residential areas as a major source of additional housing capacity. These include cooperative housing societies, DDA colonies, plotted developments, resettlement colonies, rehabilitation colonies, government housing and private group housing.

Many of these areas have ageing housing stock, under-utilised plots and low-density development despite existing roads and infrastructure. Instead of expanding only into new areas, the plan proposes using these serviced areas more intensively.

"The Plan promotes redevelopment of ageing housing stock, under-utilised plots and areas under low-density where infrastructure already exists," it says, adding that redevelopment would "create additional housing while improving roads, utilities, public spaces and community facilities."

The proposed regeneration model illustrates the scale of this densification. In the plan's illustrative example for a planned area, existing ground coverage is shown at 30–40%, with average FAR of 150–200. Under the proposed redevelopment model, FAR rises to 300, ground coverage is reduced to 30%, green/open area is set at 30%, and building height can reach G+9.

Regeneration will be undertaken only after identifying areas requiring upgradation and potential for development. Road Network Plans are to be prepared with local bodies and landowners/residents, while reorganisation and pooling of properties will be permitted to facilitate redevelopment.

"The idea is to bring together smaller plots and build vertically with lanes and bylanes on the sides in both planned and unplanned areas, following all safety and building norms. This is similar to the 'blocks' in residential areas in many other countries like the UK and USA," said a DDA official.

For regeneration schemes generally, the plan permits a maximum FAR of 1.5 times the base FAR, while amalgamation and reconstitution of plots will be allowed. It also requires Road Network Plans; service-providing agencies will be responsible for augmenting services wherever required, subject to applicable charges.

The densification strategy extends to unauthorised colonies, urban villages, slums and jhuggi-jhopri (JJ) clusters. These unplanned and unauthorised areas often have poor building conditions, inadequate physical and social infrastructure and poor accessibility, even as many have evolved into high-density, mixed-use settlements.

For unauthorised colonies, regeneration schemes can be undertaken over a minimum 2,000 sqm area. The proposed norms allow a base FAR of 350, with separate FAR provisions for amenities. Ground coverage can go up to 50% in smaller regeneration schemes and 40% in larger ones. In urban villages, the plan recognises that rapid densification, vertical redevelopment and plot subdivision have already taken place without corresponding augmentation of infrastructure and public spaces. It proposes area improvement plans, road widening, improved physical and social infrastructure, rejuvenation of water bodies and development of local green areas.

For slum and JJ clusters, the plan proposes a three-fold strategy of in-situ rehabilitation, relocation and in-situ upgrading/area improvement. Its in-situ rehabilitation model permits FAR of 500 for both the rehabilitation and remunerative components.

## UGC-NET TO BE RE-HELD

that a 100-page PDF containing handwritten questions circulated before the June 30 examination, with nearly 90 questions and answer options matching the actual paper, HT reported on July 9.

"The sociology paper had spelling, translation and typographical errors. At least 14 questions in the English question paper were repeated from the December 2024 examination paper. The case with commerce was similar," said a person familiar with the matter. The paper has 150 questions.

"Instead of dropping more than a dozen questions in each subject and keeping students concerned over repeated questions, NTA has decided to re-conduct the examinations of these three subjects," the person said.

This is the second time UGC-NET papers are being cancelled in three years. In 2024, NTA scrapped the entire exam on June 19, a day after it was conducted, after intelligence inputs indicated that the question paper had been leaked. The government then handed the matter to the Central Bureau of Investigation (CBI), which later found that the purported leaked-paper screenshot was doctored and reported no evidence of an actual paper leak.

NTA on Sunday moved to assure that the reschedule would not delay the allocation of JRF seats or of documents that certify the eligibility of candidates for assistant professor posts or PhD admissions in the subjects.

However, candidates criticised NTA's move and pointed out that they would have to prepare for the exam afresh, adding that travelling to their allocated centres was an additional expense. Some students also pointed out that the retest date was days after the Central Teacher Eligibility Test (CTET), to be held on September 6.

"What happened with the paper is not my fault, but because of NTA and its systemic failure. Why should we face these problems?" said a candidate from Jhargram, West Bengal, who appeared for the UGC-NET English paper. It was his sixth attempt.

He said he travelled nearly 450km to Burdwan and was now preparing for CTET and other examinations, making it "difficult to refocus" on the UGC-NET retest.

NTA's question-paper preparation involves multiple stages, with separate experts handling question-writing, moderation, vetting and translation.

Subject panels comprising faculties prepare a large question bank, from which moderators select questions for multiple sets. Vetters independently solve the sets and discrepancies are resolved before finalisation. The questions are then translated in various regional languages and back-translated to English to check for accuracy. Multiple sets are subsequently generated through randomisation, printed, packed and kept in secure storage until the examination.

The process is conducted in NTA's Delhi office, where subject experts work in isolation for about a week; they surrender mobile phones and other digital devices on entry, while security personnel monitor their movement and reference material is provided within the premises.

The English paper will now be held on September 9 from 9am to noon, followed by commerce from 3pm to 6pm the same day. Sociology will be held on September 10 from 9am to noon.

Candidates appearing for the retest will not be required to pay an additional examination fee.

NTA will notify the examination city, centre and admit card details separately on its official websites.

The three-hour examination comprises 150 multiple-choice questions carrying 300 marks.

In the sociology paper, candidates flagged several spelling errors, including "Ritzer" appearing as "Putzer", "Ghurye" as "Ghunye", "Parsons" as "Parsow" and "Nussbaum" as "Nusbaut", among others.

In English and commerce, candidates and coaching teachers alleged that several questions were repeated from earlier UGC-NET cycles, particularly December 2024 and 2025.

In the English paper, questions were reportedly lifted verbatim, including those on the publication year of the novel *Kanthapura*, the author of *The Life Divine*, genre-based classifications such as *The Time Machine* and *Brave New World*, and "Match the Following" questions involving critics such as Jacques Derrida and Roland Barthes. Questions on the chronology of William Shakespeare's plays and specialised literary concepts such as "Ecocriticism" and "the Flâneur" were also repeated, with the multiple-choice options in the same sequence.

In commerce, repeated questions included specific corporate tax provisions such as arm's-length pricing and TDS provisions under sections 194C and 194F, as well as accounting questions using identical numerical data for break-even analysis and Margin of Safety. Questions on capital structure theories, including the Modigliani-Miller Hypothesis, and the extended 7 Ps of service marketing were also reportedly repeated with the same multiple-choice sequences.

The NEET paper leak forced an institutional overhaul of NTA.

The agency is rebuilding its institutional capacity and reducing dependence on contractual and outsourced manpower in line with the Radhakrishnan committee's recommendations submitted in October 2024. Through various recruitment notifications between May 15 and August 6, NTA invited applications for 22 posts including for roles specialised leadership roles covering cybersecurity; test-centre operations; and vigilance, investigation and forensics. NTA on July 25 also floated a ₹7.5 crore tender to hire a professional security agency for round-the-clock security services at its headquarters on Delhi's Minto Road, regional offices in Okhla and other notified locations.

NTA conducts UGC-NET twice a year in 87 subjects in computer-based test (CBT) mode.

The agency on Sunday released provisional answer keys for 84 subjects, the results of which will be declared as scheduled.

For the three re-conducted subjects, the number of candidates qualifying for assistant professorship will be 6% of those who appeared in the June examination or the re-examination, "whichever is higher".

NTA also said that after the retest, the numbers already allocated for each subject "shall not be reduced under any circumstances".

## 22-YR-OLD KILLED AFTER BUS HITS TWO-WHEELER IN NAJAFGARH

HT Correspondent
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**NEW DELHI:** A 22-year-old man was killed and another injured in a hit-and-run after the two-wheeler they were travelling on was hit by a Delhi Transport Corporation (DTC) bus near Dichaon bus depot in Jai Vihar, Najafgarh, late on Saturday evening, police said.

The victim was identified as Sonu, a resident of Uttam Nagar. 24-year-old Sonta, a resident of Mohan Garden, who was riding pillion was injured in the accident and shifted to a hospital for treatment, police said.

The driver of the vehicle fled the spot and is yet to be apprehended, police said.

Deputy commissioner of police (DCP) Kushalpal Singh said, "The bus involved in the accident was a DTC vehicle." DTC did not respond to HT's request for a comment on the incident.

Police said that when the team reached the spot, while Sonu was dead, Sonta was alive and was subsequently taken to hospital for medical treatment.

A scooter bearing Delhi registration number was also found at the spot. Police said that both the victims work at a private firm. A forensic team was subsequently called to the spot to examine the scene and collect evidence, police said.

A case under Section 106 (causing death by negligence) of BNS has been filed at Baba Haridas Nagar police station.

## Protest after sanitation worker killed

Several sanitation workers and family members of an MCD worker staged a protest outside Lal Bahadur Shastri hospital on Sunday after the worker was stabbed to death in east Delhi's Kalyanpuri. The protesters demanded compensation along with a government job for the victim's elder brother. Police suspect a personal dispute to be behind the incident. The accused in the case has been identified, but is currently on the run, police said. ARVIND YADAV/HT PHOTO

{ MUKHERJEE NAGAR }

## Man arrested for raping 22-yr-old

**NEW DELHI:** Police have arrested a man accused of raping a 22-year-old woman at hotels in northwest Delhi on two separate occasions, an officer said on Sunday.

Police said they arrested him after the survivor filed a complaint last Sunday at Mukherjee Nagar police station.

A rape case was registered, and the accused was produced to a local court, which remanded him to judicial custody.

The woman, a makeup artist, said she met the accused last August through social media as he was in the same profession and used to post makeup-related videos. They both became friends. In July, she met him at a hotel in the Mukherjee Nagar area, where he offered a spiked soft drink and allegedly raped her, the woman said.

The survivor said the accused persuaded her not to file a police complaint and promised to marry her.

The accused tricked her again into going to a hotel in August in the GTB Nagar area, where he again raped her, police said. However, the woman sustained injuries during the sexual assault, and the accused fled from the hotel.

Following the assault, the survivor approached the police and registered a complaint.

A police officer said the survivor was provided all assistance including the medical aid and a probe is underway. HT

## 32-year-old man dies after falling into water-filled pit in Prem Nagar

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**NEW DELHI:** A 32-year-old man died after he allegedly fell into a water-filled pit in a vacant private plot while returning home allegedly in an inebriated condition in the Brij Vihar area of Prem Nagar, northwest Delhi, late Thursday night, police said on Sunday.

The victim was identified as Himanshu Pal, who worked at a private factory in Mundka, police said. "The incident took place around 11pm, when Pal was returning home. It was found that there was a vacant plot near his residence and that it had accumulated around eight to 10 feet of water," a senior police officer said.

Police said a neighbour spotted Pal floating in the water and raised an alarm, after which people from the area gathered at the spot and tried to rescue him with a rope, but in vain.

Pal's father, Raj Kumar, told investigators that his son had left home around 4pm on Thursday for some work. "Prima facie, it appears that the man may have fallen into the water-filled pit while returning home. However, all aspects of the incident are being examined," a police officer said.

Police are also looking into the circumstances leading up to Pal's fall and whether any other factors contributed to his death. "We have not ruled out any possibility at this stage", police said.

The body was sent for a post-mortem examination. The report is expected to help establish the exact cause of death. Action will be taken based on the findings. Police are also examining the circumstances surrounding the water-filled site and did not reveal whether it was filled by rainwater. Details of the owner of the plot also had not yet been disclosed.

## DDA HOUSING SCHEME: 54% FLATS SOLD ON 1ST DAY

**NEW DELHI:** Over 54% of the flats offered under the Delhi Development Authority's (DDA) Karamjeevi Awaas Yojana 2026 have been booked on the first day as the scheme rolled out, officials said on Saturday.

Out of the 1,218 flats offered by the authority, 661 have been sold, with the 1BHKs getting completely sold out. The scheme offers ready-to-move-in flats in Narela to both serving and retired government as well as corporate employees at 25% discount. Officials said bookings opened on Sunday. The discounted flats are priced ranging from ₹33.4 lakh for 1BHK units, ₹75.55 lakh for 2BHKs and ₹1.07 crore for 3BHKs. HT

## CM: Govt planning paperless cabinet

HT Correspondent
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**NEW DELHI:** Chief minister Rekha Gupta announced on Sunday that the Delhi government plans to introduce an "e-cabinet" system to make cabinet proceedings paperless, secure and faster.

The announcement followed a meeting with National Informatics Centre experts, who briefed the chief minister on similar systems used in various states and their experience with digital governance. The proposed system will enable cabinet notes, agendas, annexures, decisions and minutes to be prepared, shared and accessed digitally by ministers and officials. The documents will be securely available on tablets, reducing the need for physical files.

The system will also facilitate monitoring of cabinet decision implementation, officials said. Departments will be able to update the status of action taken, allowing the government to track whether decisions are being implemented within the stipulated timeframe. "Our priority is to ensure that better administrative decisions enabled by technology directly benefit the people," Gupta said.

### Govt hits 100 Atal Canteen target

**NEW DELHI:** With the launch of 25 new Atal Canteens on Sunday, government completed its target of setting up 100 canteens across the city, eight months after launching the scheme to provide subsidised meals. The canteens serve meals for ₹5 and have so far provided around 9.5 million subsidised meals.

### Man, on run for killing wife, held

**NEW DELHI:** The Delhi Police on Sunday said they had arrested a 40-year-old man who had been absconding for more than two months after allegedly killing his wife by slitting her throat and crushing her face with a stone in north Delhi's Bhalswa Dairy. The woman was found dead on June 6.

### 2 held week after killing 17-yr-old

**NEW DELHI:** Police said they have arrested two men from Uttarakhand for allegedly stabbing and shooting a 17-year-old boy at Lal Bagh slums in Adarsh Nagar last week. Police said the accused, Aman and Anuj, killed the boy over an alleged enmity between local groups and claiming area dominance.

The Hindustan Times
ESTABLISHED IN 1924

{ OUR TAKE }

# A road map for progress

The success of the PM's *saptadhara* focus is critcal to resolving the immediate crisis of jobs

Like every such address from the ramparts of the Red Fort over the past eight decades, Prime Minister Narendra Modi's speech to mark the 80th Independence Day combined a short-term actionable road map with the long-term path that the country should embark on.

The PM unveiled the seven streams or *saptadhara* that he believed will power India's journey to the centenary of its Independence in 1947. He correctly identified manufacturing as the first pillar. This newspaper has repeatedly noted in the past that much of India's problems with unemployment and youth discontent is tied to its failure to encourage large-scale manufacturing. But this is easier said than done, especially when a large part of the manufacturing landscape is actually in the informal sector marked by small sweatshops rather than capital-intensive, high-tech factories. Two others, devoting more attention to agriculture and technological innovation cannot come at a more urgent time, when small farmers are the mercy of increasingly volatile monsoons and climate shocks, and the IT industry — once the driver of the Indian economy and middle-class aspirations – has to quickly adapt to a world governed by breakneck innovations in AI. This government has prided itself on the expansion of infrastructure and therefore it should come as no surprise that Gati Shakti is one of the pillars. But achieving self-reliance in defence will be a tougher goal to meet, given the mixed success of indigenous programmes and the push-and-pulls of defence procurement. The focus on renewables is welcome at a time when the oil crisis has hit the country's finances, and it is always a good idea to focus on soft power to grow India's global influence.

Among the actionables that the PM mentioned, the most important is the free coaching classes that the government intends to run. Coming against the backdrop of sweeping student protests that extracted a rare resignation of a Cabinet member, the step can be seen as an outreach to young people and also an attempt to break the school-to-coaching-class-to-higher-education-institutions cycle that disadvantages many. The intention is laudable but its success will depend both on the quality of the education imparted and the scale of the solution. There is a larger issue: The importance of competitive exams didn't grow in a vacuum but is entrenched in India's political economy that offers few avenues for mobility. The problem, as this newspaper has written before, is of jobs. To resolve this crisis, the success of the *saptadhara* is imperative.

# Census as a registry of citizenship

Will the census become a registry of citizens? This is now the biggest question vis-a-vis the 2027 census exercise after the government has added sections to the schedule which seek personal details of citizens, which exist in other official and non-official databases, such as Aadhaar, passport, driving licence and mobile numbers. Such details have never been sought before in a census exercise in India. Once collected, it will make the census closer to a citizens' register than just an anonymised enumeration exercise that it has always been.

The exercise has its administrative upsides and it might allow various government databases to talk to each other. But its privacy and logistical concerns might need to be weighed carefully by constitutional experts. On the face of it, this will turn the census into a registry of citizens rather than an anonymous enumeration whose data are never shared outside the Registrar General of India below a certain level of granularity. What will complicate matters further is the government's repeated insistence on the fact that numerous other government-issued documents such as Aadhaar, voter ID cards, and even passports do not make a sufficient proof of citizenship in India.

Constitutional complexities aside, the move also raises questions from a logistical point of view. Unlike the census — a decadal exercise — most of the other information being sought are more fluid in nature and their count can vary significantly between two census exercises. Because there already exists a count of these documents in the country, the only logical explanation of collecting such data with the personal enumeration part of the census can be to match the two.

In an ideal world, this should have happened after a detailed discussion in parliament and outside it.

{ GRAND STRATEGY }

Happymon Jacob

# Mecca pact: Interests primary, not alliances

Our reflexive scepticism towards the shifting dynamics in West Asia indicates that certain entrenched habits are still overriding fresh strategic assessments of the region

Lord Palmerston, the British foreign secretary, told the House of Commons in 1848 that Britain had no eternal allies and no perpetual enemies, and that only its interests were eternal and perpetual. The line has survived because it is as close to realpolitik as anything can be. But the interests argument is easier made than related policy framed – what makes for national "interest" is not easy to answer, more so when it keeps changing. As a result, States and strategic thinkers are poor at identifying national interests, especially during times of geopolitical shifts. So, they go by past experiences, received wisdom and past friendships, enmity and neutrality. Our reflexive scepticism towards the shifting dynamics in West Asia — from the so-called Mecca Pact to Ankara's regional manoeuvring — indicates that certain entrenched habits are still overriding fresh strategic assessments of the region.

Consider how we view two of the three parties to the pact. Turkey has been designated as an adversary. After all, Ankara backed Pakistan throughout Operation Sindoor, and it has been vocally uncharitable about India in the past – and that is Turkey's fault, not ours. So while our reasons to view Turkey in the "adversary's camp" are genuine, doing so may not be in our interest.

We may have also put the other signatory to the pact, Saudi Arabia, in the enemy camp due to two reasons. Reason one is Pakistan: Riyadh's relationship with Islamabad is old, solid and predates India's partnerships in the region. The other reason is the UAE, around whom we have built our Gulf policy in recent years. With Abu Dhabi, Delhi has a trade agreement, growing investments, I2U2, and so on. Today, our friendship with Abu Dhabi and enmity with Islamabad have started colouring our relationship with Riyadh.

In ordinary times, New Delhi could afford an imperfect relationship with Riyadh; today, the Mecca Pact makes any diplomatic distance far too costly.

For sure, the pact among Saudi Arabia, Turkey and Pakistan places them in a military camp opposed to India more as a function of the pact than as a function of the intentions in Riyadh or Ankara. One can interpret that their declaration that an armed attack on one will be treated as an attack on all three is directly aimed at India, thanks to our intensely adversarial situation with Islamabad. But let's look at the record of such recent pacts, which is less dramatic.

Recall that Pakistan and Saudi Arabia had signed a bilateral version of the same agreement in September 2025. Iran struck Saudi territory repeatedly thereafter: Neither Riyadh sought Pakistani military intervention, nor Pakistan considered itself under attack. Now, after the signing of the Mecca agreement, Houthi forces struck Saudis again, and neither Ankara nor Islamabad did anything. So, I have little reason to believe that if Pakistan is under Indian attack tomorrow, Saudi Arabia and Turkey will come attacking India.

There is another reason why I think so. Riyadh has clearly sought to minimise the impact of the agreement itself. On the very day of signing, deputy minister for public diplomacy Rayed Krimly said the agreement was not a military axis, not a sectarian bloc, not linked to nuclear ambitions or an arms race, no threat to any country in the region, and no replacement for existing agreements with other States. That is way too explicit on what it is not.

Ankara has sought to institutionalise the pact even as Krimly played it down. Turkish foreign minister Hakan Fidan has compared the collective defence provision to NATO's Article 5, discussed a ministerial mechanism and a permanent secretariat in Saudi Arabia, and said the arrangement should not remain limited to three countries, with Egypt among potential candidates. Notably, he has also said it targets no State.

The one capital that has sought to play it up is Pakistan and its analysts. Pakistan's defence minister Khawaja Asif called for Muslim nations to unite against Israel, explicitly characterising such an alliance as a NATO of the Islamic world. Deputy PM Ishaq Dar later stated that the agreement was purely defensive and directed at no country. Some Pakistani analysts have gone further even speculating about coordinated command and control.

Holding grudges is the opposite of geopolitical agility, and they limit our options in a multi-aligned world AFP

When it comes to a military pact, the deterrence value is set by its most careful member, which in this case is Saudi Arabia. Riyadh has the money but has the least appetite for anyone else's war. So the capital doing the loudest talking, Islamabad, is not the capital that will eventually make the decision. That is the reassuring half of my argument.

The not-so-reassuring half has got to do with the changing nature of regional geopolitics and military dynamics. At the most basic level, the pact is evidence that West Asia is reorganising itself around the failure of American security guarantees, and that middle powers in the region are now keen on creating their own arrangements. So, we in India should be reading this as a description of the broader strategic environment we operate in rather than as a move directed against us.

This takes me back to Palmerston. If interests are the only permanent thing, then we must identify them, and revise our interests when circumstances change, as they have now in West Asia. Our interests in restive West Asia are energy, millions of our citizens there, sea lanes, and the potential corridors to Europe. And those interests of ours are hardly served by permanently dividing the region into camps – friendly and unfriendly.

The case I am making is for setting aside old grudges, for reasons arising out of pragmatism and not out of charity. Holding grudges is the opposite of geopolitical agility, and they limit our options in a multi-aligned world where options are more important than ever.

India has spent a decade arguing for a multipolar order, the importance of multialignment, and for the right of States to hedge against and refuse binary choices. Saudi Arabia has now exercised that right, as has Turkey. This is what our own argument looks like when other countries practise it. The world is multi-aligned today; why shouldn't we be too?

*Happymon Jacob is founder and director, Council for Strategic and Defense Research, and editor, INDIA'S WORLD magazine. The views expressed are personal*

# More autonomy for the IITs will benefit India

There may be no better symbol of independent India's ambition than IIT Kharagpur. It rose from the grounds of the Hijli Detention Camp, where British forces imprisoned freedom fighters and, in 1931, shot dead two unarmed detainees. Less than two decades later, India transformed that site of repression into its first Indian Institute of Technology, turning ground once used to suppress Indian minds into a place that would produce engineers and scientists who helped shape the modern world.

As IIT Kharagpur celebrates its platinum jubilee, that history carries a larger lesson: India does its best work when it has the confidence to trust its own talent rather than wait for the West to define excellence.

Vivek Wadhwa

The IIT system became one of post-independence India's greatest institutional achievements. Its graduates built domestic industries, helped power Silicon Valley and rose to lead some of the world's most influential technology companies. Yet India still underestimates the scientific and engineering capability within the IITs and many other institutions of similar calibre.

For decades, Indian institutions have been pressured to mirror Western universities such as MIT, Stanford and Harvard. The prescription is always the same: Spend more on basic research, publish more papers, expand tenure tracks, improve citation counts and climb global rankings.

The American university system has many strengths, and I have spent the latter part of my career in it, but India should not copy its many weaknesses.

American universities spend tens of billions of dollars every year on research and generate huge amounts of intellectual property, yet only a small fraction becomes companies, products or technologies that reach society. The system is built around professors publishing papers that almost no one outside their narrow fields reads, because publications and citations are what help secure tenure, effectively babu-style lifetime employment. The result is a powerful incentive to optimise for academic recognition rather than for turning knowledge into invention.

That is what makes the changes I am seeing in India so significant: the IITs are beginning to move in the opposite direction.

I have worked closely with IIT Madras, IIT Delhi and IIT Kharagpur and consider directors of all three my friends. What I have seen is a profound shift from when I first began studying Indian engineering education almost two decades ago at Duke and Harvard.

Like their Western counterparts, Indian universities were once insular, suspicious of private industry and assumed that academics alone knew which problems mattered. Today, these institutions actively seek collaboration with industry, encourage translational research, and want technologies to move from laboratories into the real world.

After moving the R&D of my Silicon Valley company, Vionix Biosciences, to the IITs, I have seen firsthand what this new model can make possible. The technical depth, motivation and willingness to tackle extremely hard problems among the faculty and students I work with across engineering, physics, biotechnology, medicine and artificial intelligence are exceptional, particularly at a time when many of the brightest graduates in the West are drawn toward the latest technology fad.

The IITs are delightfully competing with one another to create impact. They want faculty working on important problems, students building things, technologies being commercialized and research becoming products, companies and solutions. Government policy has helped drive this change, as has the determination of the leaders running these institutions.

The biggest constraint I see now is bureaucracy. Layers of mindless approvals, committees and administrative rules inherited from the British Raj still consume enormous institutional energy. Leaders such as Suman Chakraborty at IIT Kharagpur are pushing hard to make their institutions more entrepreneurial and impact-driven, but they still have to navigate administrative structures that bog everything down.

The government must cut these institutions loose: Give IIT directors greater autonomy, strip away unnecessary reporting and outdated rules, make industry collaboration easier, and give leaders the authority to fire the entrenched bureaucrats who resist change.

India must also stop asking the West what a great research university should look like. It should instead focus science and engineering on the problems India and humanity urgently need solved.

That means going deep into physics, chemistry, biology, materials science, engineering and artificial intelligence to tackle clean water, early cancer detection, affordable diagnostics, energy storage, food security, pollution and advanced manufacturing. These are not lesser forms of research because they begin with practical problems; many demand fundamental scientific breakthroughs.

The strongest model is one in which industry identifies real-world problems, universities provide scientific depth and young talent, and government supports long-term missions too broad for any one company to finance. Making that collaboration easier could become one of India's strongest competitive advantages.

Imagine IITs competing not merely on placement packages, citation counts and global rankings, but on who develops the most affordable cancer diagnostic, cleans the most contaminated groundwater, produces a breakthrough battery, reduces agricultural losses or builds technologies that improve millions of lives.

IIT Kharagpur's platinum jubilee should therefore be seen as more than an anniversary. It began as an assertion that independent India could define its own future, then became the model for the IIT system that followed. Its next chapter can make an even larger statement: that India no longer needs to imitate the world's great research institutions, because it is capable of creating a better model of its own.

*Vivek Wadhwa is CEO, Vionix Biosciences. The views expressed are personal*

{ HARIVANSH } DEPUTY CHAIRMAN, RAJYA SABHA

**The Constitution has a provision for delimitation ... you've (different Union governments) postponed delimitation twice**

{ STRAIGHTFORWARD }

Shashi Shekhar

# India @79: Much is done, much remains to be done

After the Independence Day euphoria, let's now ponder over some complex issues facing the nation. What are these?

Let me take you back to Uttar Pradesh of the 1960s. My generation was born in this decade. Our democratic values had been strengthened after conducting two general elections and many epoch-making works were initiated.

Cities, at the time, didn't get electricity for hours, and most of the villages were *batti-vihin* (without electricity). During this time, India suffered catastrophic droughts and famine. Ganga's flow almost dried up.

I have vivid recollection of ration shops that would shut before many in the long queues could secure their ration. That decade, India and Pakistan got into a war. The exemplary bravery of our soldiers assuaged, to some extent, our deep hurt from the defeat at the hands of the Chinese some years ago.

Prime Minister Jawaharlal Nehru too passed away during the decade. His replacement Lal Bahadur Shastri's tenure was short. Indira Gandhi's ascent was the result of Shastri's untimely death. The emergence of dynastic politics can be traced to this. In those times, Dalits couldn't fetch water from many wells and lakes, and couldn't ride a horse for their wedding procession. Muslims were relatively better placed, but were weighed down by the unnecessary guilt of Partition. The country got the first Muslim president and its only woman prime minister (till date) in the same decade. During the same decade, the backward classes' impact on politics in the southern states signalled a change in future political equations.

Baby steps were taken in the field of sports, education, technology, and science. In the 1960 Rome Olympics, Milkha Singh won hearts globally though he failed to secure a medal. It was the golden era of Indian hockey and football. In cricket, India defeated New Zealand under the captaincy of Mansoor Ali Khan Pataudi. It was the time when the Indian Institutes of Management (IIMs) were established. The first rocket was fired from Thumba space centre and the Indian Space Research Organisation came into existence. Landmark progress was made in nuclear energy, and India's historic Green Revolution also took off.

Today, India is on its way to become an economic superpower. But disparities remain.

New Delhi has witnessed a string of powerful governments since 2009. Great progress has been made in the field of access to electricity, health and education. But there's still a wide chasm between government data and the ground reality. We have the world's largest pool of graduates, but 45% of them can't secure a job commensurate with their degree.

Even nature seems to be adversely disposed towards us. The monsoon season is on, but 26 rivers in Bihar are almost dry. Reports from Uttarakhand suggest it has lost 25% of its forest cover. Today, the rains soak the bare hillside, creating havoc. On the eve of Independence Day, 14 people are battling for life, victims of debris flow in a tunnel in Chamoli.

In such times, I am reminded of those small towns where I grew up. Though electricity or tap water wasn't available in every house, but rains didn't lead to deadly water-logging either. Today, even in the financial capital Mumbai, water-logging becomes a life threatening event for the commuters. While villages are emptying out, tier 2 and tier 3 towns are witnessing a boom in multi-storied apartment complexes.

If we need to maintain a balance in our demography, we must create employment opportunities in the villages. Along with secure borders, we need to ensure social and environmental security with equal sensitivity. Since the economic liberalisation of 1991, we have tried to turn Bharat into India. Economic inequality has gone through the roof. Such inequality led to the demise of the Soviet Union and has redrew the maps of many European nations.

But there's no need for pessimism. We know how to move ahead, breaking the chains of adversity. Many rulers came to this land and became a part of this country. We learnt from everyone and internalised those teachings.

Seventy-nine years of Independence have progressively added strength to the narrative.

Today, those born in the 1960s, living in the sixth decade of their lives, draw joy from the fact that we are still a young nation. Opportunities, energy, and youth are complementary to each other. But there's another side to the same story. We will start aging in the next decade. Three decades from now, India will have more aged than young. Are we ready to face that challenge? We'll need to think about it today. Why not begin the process today? We will have to think about how we can bring along those who are left behind.

There can be no better start to the 80th year of our Independence.

*Shashi Shekhar is editor-in-chief, Hindustan. The views expressed are personal*

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Jared Kushner AFP

## TRUMP'S ENVOY KUSHNER MEETS HAMAS CHIEF TO PUSH GAZA PLAN

**AFP & Reuters**
letters@hindustantimes.com

**JERUSALEM/CAIRO:** US President Donald Trump's son-in-law and envoy Jared Kushner met Hamas's new chief Khalil al-Hayya in Egypt on Sunday, sources with knowledge of the talks told AFP, in a push to revive a Gaza peace plan rejected by Israel. Kushner called for "concrete, verifiable steps" and relayed a message that "Gaza can never again be a source of terror for Israel", said one source who spoke on condition of anonymity due to the sensitivity of the talks.

The new Hamas chief took part in the discussions in the Egyptian Mediterranean city of El-Alamein, making his first trip since assuming leadership of the group in July. In the talks with Kushner, Hamas again voiced its commitment to the agreement, another source with knowledge of the talks said.

A senior Israeli official said Kushner and Nickolay Mladenov, Trump's Board of Peace envoy for Gaza are scheduled to meet on Monday with Israeli Prime Minister Benjamin Netanyahu, who on August 9 said Trump's latest roadmap for Gaza peace was "unacceptable".

The Israeli official said that Israel was concerned about Washington's demand to end targeted assassinations of Hamas militants in Gaza as the group rebuilds its forces.

Meanwhile, the Israeli military said on Sunday that its aircraft struck two Islamic Jihad and Hamas militants in Khan Younis and Nuseirat.

# 'Oman talks, reopening of strait separate issues'

**HT Correspondent**
letters@hindustantimes.com

**NEW DELHI:** Iranian foreign minister Abbas Araghchi has said that the ongoing negotiations between Iran and Oman are "completely separate" from the issue of reopening the Strait of Hormuz.

In remarks made to Iranian outlet Shahrara News, Araghchi clarified that ongoing discussions with Oman focus specifically on designating updated navigation lanes for vessel transit, as previous maritime routes are no longer operational, Al Jazeera reported. "Our negotiations with Oman are ongoing. That is a completely separate matter. It is a technical issue concerning the designation of maritime routes in the Strait of Hormuz for the passage of ships," Araghchi said.

He said that because the earlier transit routes are no longer functional, a new navigation path must be established. "For now, we are designing a temporary route, which can then, at a later stage, be turned into a final route," he noted.

While expressing optimism that an agreement could be reached soon, Araghchi emphasised that establishing a new maritime channel does not automatically signal the reopening of the Strait of Hormuz. "We may reach an outcome soon, but I want to emphasise that these negotiations and the reopening of the Strait of Hormuz are two separate issues. This is a technical negotiation concerning the designation of a maritime route."

Araghchi stressed that once the temporary route is finalised, any decision regarding the resumption of shipping through the strategic waterway will depend on US fulfilling specific obligations. "Once this route has been determined, whether the Strait will be reopened or not will depend on the fulfilment of other conditions to which the United States must adhere."

A man rides on his motorbike past a billboard with a message that reads in Farsi: "We must rise up" and an image of the late Iranian Supreme Leader Ayatollah Ali Khamenei, in Tehran. AP

## Iran offers $30,000 bounty for killing, capturing US soldiers

**Agence France-Presse**
letters@hindustantimes.com

**TEHRAN:** Iran's military announced on Sunday that it was offering a bounty equivalent to $30,000 for killing or capturing US soldiers, with the reward doubled if carried out by a woman.

Army chief Amir Hatami said the plan had been drawn up following a "large number of requests" to participate, according to the IRNA state news agency.

There has been no known deployment of US ground forces in Iran during the Middle East war, with the exception of a rescue mission in April for a downed American airman.

Hatami did not provide any details on where or when the killing or capturing of US soldiers was expected to take place.

"Anyone who kills or captures and hands over an invading American military personnel will receive a reward equivalent to $30,000 or 5 billion tomans from the Islamic Republic of Iran's Army," Hatami said, using an informal unit equivalent to 10,000 Iranian rials. "Courageous Iranian women who carry out such an action will receive double the reward," he added.

Hatami repeated Iran's call for the US to leave the Middle East, and said "they no longer have permission to enter the Persian Gulf, the Gulf of Oman or the Strait of Hormuz".

The war between Tehran and Washington began on February 28 when the United States and Israel attacked Iran.

## 3 MISSING PILOTS: IRAN SAYS QATAR THWARTING PROBE

**Agence France-Presse**
letters@hindustantimes.com

**TEHRAN:** Iran accused Qatar on Sunday of thwarting efforts to work out what happened to three pilots Tehran says were captured during the Middle East war, though the Gulf state has denied detaining them.

The Islamic republic had previously reported one pilot killed and others missing after a sortie to Qatar in March, but had not claimed at the time that any of them had been captured.

"A team of experts from the Iranian Air Force has been waiting for several months to travel to Qatar to conduct an on-site investigation," said General Mohammad Bagherzadeh of the Iranian armed forces.

"However, due to persistent delays by Qatari authorities, the return of our brave pilots to their homeland remains impossible," he added, according to the Tasnim news agency.

He called on Doha to authorise the team to travel to Qatar.

Bagherzadeh has accused Qatar of having captured three Iranian pilots who were carrying out an operation against the US' Al Udeid air base in early March and demanded their release.

"Javad Salehi, Abdolmajid Dashtian and Omran Behravesshian have been held by Qatari forces for six months," Bagherzadeh said in a letter addressed to the International Committee of the Red Cross.

Qatar denied holding the pilots and said an invitation had been sent to Iran "to be briefed on the details of the search & rescue operations in April, but the Iranian side has yet to respond".

Last month, Iran said it had retrieved the body of pilot Majid Kazemi, who was killed during the attack on Al Udeid base.

# ArcelorMittal's plant hit in Russia-Ukraine crossfire

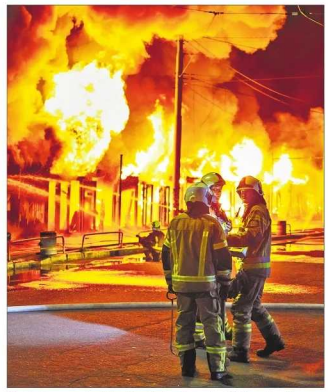
**KYIV/BUCHAREST:** Strikes killed 16 people in Russia and Ukraine, authorities said on Sunday, as waves of drones and missiles pummelled civilian infrastructure on both sides.

In Russia, swarms of Ukrainian drones killed five people in the southern Rostov region, regional governor Yuri Slusar said. Three more people were killed in the Belgorod and Moscow regions, along with three others in parts of Ukraine occupied by Russia.

In Ukraine, a barrage of Russian drones and missiles killed two people and wounded 14 at ArcelorMittal's steel plant in Kryvyi Rih, President Volodymyr Zelensky's hometown. Strikes also hit other regions, killing two people in the southeastern Zaporizhzhia region and one in the border region of Sumy.

Meanwhile, a Spanish fighter jet on Sunday shot down a drone that had breached Romanian airspace near the border with Ukraine and Moldova. A growing number of drones have crossed into Nato states as Russia pursues its invasion of Ukraine.

AGENCE FRANCE-PRESSE



Firefighters work at the site of a book market hit by a Russian missile strike in Kyiv, Ukraine, on Sunday. REUTERS

### BBC seeks Trump's family testimony in $10 billion suit

**LONDON:** The BBC asked a US court for help in getting documents and testimony from members of US President Donald Trump's family in connection with his $10-billion defamation lawsuit against the British broadcaster, a court document showed.

Lawyers for the BBC argued that Ivanka Trump, her husband Jared Kushner, and Donald Trump, Jr. have "personal knowledge" and likely have records relevant to elements of Trump's claims against the broadcaster, according to a filing on Friday in federal court in Florida. AP

### Calls for UK inquiry into 'hounding' of ex-Cambridge professor

**LONDON:** More than 31,000 people, including several MPs, have signed a petition urging UK Prime Minister Andy Burnham to hold a public inquiry into alleged media harassment of the late academic Jason Arday, the organisers said on Sunday. The youngest-ever black professor at Cambridge University was found dead on Friday. AFP

### In Spain's Ceuta, hundreds of migrants demand asylum

**MADRID:** Hundreds of migrants who entered Spain's enclave of Ceuta staged a protest on Sunday, urging Spanish authorities to grant them asylum. They were among 5,000 to 8,000 who remain in Ceuta after the border crossing two weeks ago that saw over 72,000 people surge into the tiny territory of about 80,000. The vast majority returned voluntarily in the following days. REUTERS

### Colombia leader asks Trump to suspend tariffs over quake

**BOGOTA:** Colombia's new President Abelardo de la Espriella has called on his US counterpart Donald Trump to suspend 12.5% tariffs currently targeting the nation, which is reeling after a deadly earthquake. AFP

# Waterways may get ₹10k-cr cargo boost

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**Centre seeks to develop waterways as comprehensive economic corridors rather than isolated stretches of navigation.** HT

**NEW DELHI:** India is stepping up its inland waterways push after cargo traffic surged nearly eightfold in just over a decade. The government now plans to develop more than a dozen new national waterways (NWs) over next five to 10 years, with investments of over ₹10,000 crore, two people aware of the matter said. The next leg will also focus on turning them into commercially-viable corridors.

The push aims to expand India's operational waterways network and achieve the Maritime Amrit Kaal Vision 2047 target of having more than 50 national waterways capable of handling cargo and passenger traffic well ahead of target.

The government has also identified 19 more waterways, primarily for cruise tourism and passenger ferry operations, based on techno-economic feasibility studies and detailed project reports. Some of these could subsequently be upgraded for cargo movement, said the first person quoted above.

Cargo movement on national waterways rose nearly eightfold from 29 million tonnes (mt) in 2014-15 to 218 mt in 2025-26, surpassing the 200 mt target for 2030. "We have achieved the 2030 target...in FY26 itself," said the second person, adding that development of more waterways would help India move towards the 2047 aim of 500 mt ahead of schedule.

Under the National Waterways Act, 2016, 111 inland waterways have been declared as national waterways, covering about 20,187km across 23 states and four Union territories. Of these, 32, spanning a navigable length of 5,155km, are now operational for cargo and passenger movement.

Queries emailed to the ministry of ports, shipping and waterways went unanswered.

Nearly 85% existing cargo traffic is now concentrated on four major waterways: NW-1, the Ganga-Bhagirathi-Hooghly system; NW-91, the Shastri River-Jaigad Creek system; NW-100, the Tapi River; and NW-10, the Amba River.

Connectivity is key to success. "Waterways will deliver their full value only if they're planned alongside the road and highway network, not in isolation," said Sanjay Kumar Sinha, founder and managing director, Chaitanya Projects Consultancy. He said first- and last-mile connectivity to industrial clusters and terminals would determine success.

The government has also started work on supporting infrastructure. A ship repair facility is nearing completion at Pandu in Assam, while facilities are planned at Varanasi and Patna. A 70-acre freight village is being developed in Varanasi by National Highways Logistics Management Ltd, an armof the National Highways Authority of India, with a special purpose vehicle set up for a multimodal logistics hub.

Experts caution against developing all waterways together. "The opportunity is less about developing entire network uniformly and more about identifying and scaling commercially-viable corridors," said Bhavik Vora, partner at Grant Thornton Bharat. He said waterways with industrial demand, year-round navigability and connections to ports, rail and road networks were more likely to attract private capital.

Kushal Kumar Singh, partner, Deloitte India, said the mode offered a "significant cost advantage" over road and rail, but cautioned that seasonal water flow, siltation and navigation constraints would determine which rivers could be viable freight channels.

Private investment is, therefore, likely to remain selective. The 2025 regulations allowing private companies to develop and operate inland waterway terminals aim to create clear norms for investment. However, investors will look for assured cargo volumes, reliable fairway depths, terminal utilization and predictable revenue streams.

"Bankability depends heavily on clear risk distribution between the government and private concessionaires," Sinha said, adding that viability-gap funding could be key for important corridors with long payback time.

Pushpank Kaushik, CEO and head of business development at Jassper Shipping, said new waterways could "drastically cut costs of logistics" while lowering pressure on roads and railways and boosting hinterland connectivity.

# Closing auction volumes crash in last 15 mins

**Ram Sahgal & Srushti Vaidya**
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**MUMBAI:** The final 15 minutes of the trading day used to be the Street's most crowded, as proprietary traders, retail investors, arbitrage funds and jobbers jostled with institutional investors for the winning trade.

The debut of the closing auction session (CAS) has flipped the script: trading has hit rock-bottom as most domestic traders and retail investors have stepped aside, turning the once-frenetic close into the leanest window of the day, a *Mint* analysis found.

Earlier this month, stock exchanges rolled out the 15-minute CAS system to determine official daily stock closing prices, replacing the decades-old 30-minute Volume-Weighted Average Price (VWAP) model.

Initially restricted to 213 stocks available for derivatives trading, the transition aims to curb end-of-day price manipulation and align Indian equity markets with global standards. However, the new system got off to a rocky start, with limited volumes and key indices on NSE and BSE closing divergently.

The *Mint* analysis of NSE trading volumes since CAS began on 3 August found that the last 15 minutes coinciding with the auction have become the least busy among all similar windows during the day, pointing to the traders and investors missing at the day's end.

Data from NSE was used for the analysis as the exchange accounts for 93.1% of the cash market share, with BSE having the rest.

Indian markets open at 9.15 am for the continuous trading session (CTS) which runs till 3.15 pm, after which CAS begins. The analysis found that since the new system began, the CAS window accounted for just 1.59% of the 1.43 billion average daily volume (ADV) of shares traded during CTS. This was even lower than the average of the least active CTS between 1:30pm and 1:45 pm, which accounted for 2.2% of the total ADV during the period. Ironically, the last 15 minutes under the continuous session was the busiest trading window during the VWAP days, when it accounted for high double-digit volumes.

The busiest trading window was at the market opening between 9:15am and 9:30 am, accounting for 13.1% of ADV and the second-highest was between the 3-3:15 pm window, the analysis showed.

**Small investors and arbitrage funds have largely stayed away from closing auctions.** PTI

The analysis splits the day's session into 25 fifteen-minute windows. It takes the average of the total volumes of eligible 213 stocks from 3 -14 August and then takes an average of each of the 25 window's volumes over 10 days. Each window's daily average is compared with the total daily average.

To illustrate, the ADV of 213 stocks over 10 trading days is 1.43 billion shares. The ADV of the CAS window is 22.89 million shares, accounting for just 1.6% of the total ADV.

The analysis drew mixed reactions—some brokers said CAS volumes would increase as participation becomes more diversified from the current passive investors like index funds and exchange-traded funds and high-frequency traders (HFTs) to retail, mutual funds and other traders.

"Participation is low because this is the initial phase of CAS," said D.K. Aggarwal, chairman and managing director, SMC Capitals Ltd. "Brokers are working towards increasing retail participation by displaying the market data during the auction session in a more upfront manner. As investors adapt to the new system, volumes would increase."

However, another broker said the "Indian market microstructure" was unlike that in major markets of the US, UK and Hong Kong, all of which run closing auctions.

"For one, market-making is permitted during CAS in other major global exchanges to ensure that spreads between buy and sell trades remain narrow and no wide divergence takes place between the close of CTS and the end of the auction. Secondly, the SLBM (securities lending and borrowing mechanism) segment is more vibrant in those markets than in India, where volumes are very low, and the process and costs are a challenge," the broker said, requesting anonymity.

Under SLBM, those not owning shares can borrow them for a fee and a margin, sell them in the market, and buy them back after a stipulated period to return to the lender. Lending fees show SLBM volumes are quite low—for instance, the fees for July were a paltry ₹115 crore against an average daily turnover of ₹1.32 trillion.

"Some HFTs are requesting Sebi to designate them as market-makers during the auction session to reduce the divergence pre- and post-auction in eligible stocks," added the broker cited earlier.

A query to Sebi on this remained unanswered.

Market-making is the practice of an exchange-empanelled participant offering tight buy-sell quotes to improve liquidity.

# Yotta Data eyes $1.5 bn fundraise in FY27

**Yadukrishna C.S. & Shouvik Das**
yadukrishna.cs@livemint.com

**MUMBAI/NEW DELHI:** Yotta Data Services plans to raise $1.5 billion by the end of the current fiscal year (FY27), with private-equity funding ahead of its planned India listing determining how much it ultimately seeks from the public market.

The Mumbai-based data centre company is targeting the fourth quarter for its initial public offering (IPO), subject to approval from the Securities and Exchange Board of India (Sebi). The IPO could raise as much as $400 million, with the bulk of the $1.5 billion potentially coming from a pre-IPO round.

"Our $1.5 billion fund-raise is a combination of pre-IPO fundraising, as well as an IPO. We are targeting Q4 of this fiscal year, subject to Sebi approval—we're working towards ensuring compliance," Sunil Gupta, co-founder and chief executive officer (CEO) of Yotta, said in an interview. "The idea is that a big part of this $1.5 billion may get closed in the pre-IPO round itself, for which we're in touch with large funds based in the US, and also those with India offices." Gupta said the eventual IPO size will depend on how much Yotta raises beforehand. "The final size of the IPO will be dictated by how much money we raise pre-IPO; the size of the IPO can be up to $400 million."

Yotta had earlier planned to list in the US but has now shifted its focus to India, where Gupta said the company's sovereign-cloud business makes a domestic listing a better fit.

"(My) business proposition is sovereign. My complete build-out is in India, and the government is a huge customer for my entire sovereign cloud—which India's private sector will also adopt as they understand geopolitical risks. The nudge from the government for this was clear: why are you raising (funds) outside? Why not within India?," Gupta said. Yotta was co-founded in 2019 by Gupta and Darshan Hiranandani, chief executive officer of real estate firm Hiranandani Group. The company reported revenue of ₹890.7 crore and a profit of ₹11.1 crore for the year ended March 2025, show disclosures made by the privately held firm with the ministry of corporate affairs.

The $1.5 billion fundraise is only the next step in a much larger capital push. Yotta has drawn up plans to raise $8.5 billion by 2029, even as it aims to more than quadruple its installed data centre capacity from 180MW to 800MW.

Much of that capital will be needed to finance Nvidia chips and the infrastructure required to provide companies with the computing power needed for artificial intelligence (AI). Yotta expects to increase the number of Nvidia chips installed across its data centres from 37,000 to 85,000 by the end of this fiscal.

India's data-centre market is being driven by a combination of regulatory requirements and surging demand for computing capacity. Reserve Bank of India requires payment data to be stored domestically, while Sebi has similar requirements for market participants.

## TAX AMNESTY FOR UNDISCLOSED FOREIGN ASSETS OPEN TILL DEC 31

**NEW DELHI:** India's tax amnesty scheme for small taxpayers to declare certain undeclared foreign assets of up to ₹5 crore ($523,889) opened on Sunday and will be available until December 31, the government said.

India's finance minister announced the scheme in her February 1 budget, targeting small taxpayers such as students and non-resident Indians.

Taxpayers with undisclosed foreign income of up to ₹1 crore can use the scheme until December 31, 2026, by paying 30% tax and an equal amount as a penalty. The market value of assets would be calculated as of March 31, 2026. REUTERS

## SEVEN FIRMS LINE UP ₹6,400-CRORE IPOs THIS WEEK

**NEW DELHI:** The primary market is set for another busy week, with seven companies, including Blackstone-backed Horizon Industrial Parks and Lalithaa Jewellery Mart, set to raise over ₹6,400 crore collectively through initial public offerings (IPOs).

The upcoming issues follow the launch of five IPOs this week. Horizon Industrial Parks will kick off the week on August 17 with its ₹2,600-crore IPO, followed by jewellery retailer Lalithaa Jewellery Mart's ₹1,700-crore issue on the same day.

Shankesh Jewellers and film and television producer Sunshine Pictures will open their IPOs on August 18, raising ₹367 crore and ₹282 crore, respectively.

Gaja Alternative Asset Management, which operates under the Gaja Capital brand, will launch its ₹550-crore IPO on August 19, Tempsens Instruments (India) will open its issue on August 20 and an integrated gold and silver platform Augmont Enterprises will float its ₹825-crore IPO on August 21.

Together, the seven companies are looking to raise more than ₹6,400 crore through public issues, making it another busy week for the primary market.

Funds raised through the fresh issue will largely be used for business expansion, capital expenditure, debt repayment and other corporate purposes, while proceeds from the OFS will go to the selling shareholders.

With the addition of these issues, the number of companies launching IPOs in 2026 is expected to rise to 55, industry data showed.

Horizon Industrial Parks' ₹2,600-crore issue comprises entirely a fresh issue and has a price band of ₹57-60 per share. The company plans to use the proceeds to repay borrowings.

Lalithaa Jewellery Mart has fixed a price band of ₹190-201 per share. Its ₹1,700-crore issue comprises a fresh issue of up to ₹1,200 crore and an OFS of up to ₹500 crore.

Shankesh Jewellers' ₹367-crore issue comes with a price band of ₹88-93 per share. The IPO comprises a fresh issue of up to 2.95 crore equity shares and an OFS of up to 1 crore equity shares.

## { THE CROSSWORDS }

### CRYPTIC CLUES

**ACROSS**

1 The pervading mood all round the world (10)
8 Funny - there's nothing in numerals (5)
9 It may show interest in Paris for example (7)
10 It's expected to be unaffected (7)
11 Show some response concerning part of the play (5)
12 A treatment for ten apparently starting lunch (6)
14 Translation from a Carib language (6)
17 Pass one bill in ten after amendment (5)
19 Trappings of power in revolutionary Algeria (7)
21 Giving money perhaps but wary about it (7)
22 Cars peculiar to USA (5)
23 Don't join in the playreading? (4,2,4)

**DOWN**

2 Tried at this, or just tried (7)
3 He's so upset about a bit of credit (5)
4 A jam that may have onions in it! (6)
5 This moth could be called a butterfly (7)
6 Spare one of the crowd (5)
7 A cult sport designed for the very rich (10)
8 The secret is boldness (10)
13 Point to it and select a carp (7)
15 Hold up of potted lobster (7)
16 Examine a name written in coloured pencil (6)
18 Not all separate (5)
20 A note on the file provides understanding (5)

**PUZZLE 17566** © Gemini Crosswords 2018 All rights reserved

### QUICK CLUES

**ACROSS**

1 Remarkable (10)
8 A freshwater diving bird (5)
9 Make amends for (7)
10 Left out (7)
11 Had (5)
12 Prevailing order of things (6)
14 Tense and restless (2,4)
17 Seek the favour of (5)
19 Bold feat (7)
21 Rejection (7)
22 Protest (5)
23 Conform to expected conduct (3,3,4)

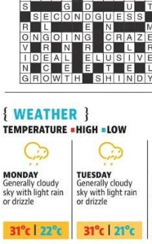
**DOWN**

2 Initial (7)
3 Fix in upright position (5)
4 Cook to excess (6)
5 Tropical cyclone (7)
6 Hanker (5)
7 Practice no longer observed (4,6)
8 State one's opinion publicly (2,2,6)
13 French painter and sculptor (7)
15 Janitor (7)
16 An abundance (6)
18 Out of condition (5)
20 Ride a bicycle (5)

### YESTERDAY'S SOLUTIONS (17565)

CRYPTIC

QUICK



## { SUDOKU }

DIFFICULTY LEVEL ★★★

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| 5 | 1 | | | 6 | | | | 7 |
| 1 | | | | | 6 | | 4 | |
| | | | 3 | 7 | | | 8 | 2 |
| | | | | | | 9 | | |

Fill in all the squares in the grid so that each row, column and each of the 9X9 squares contains all the digits from 1 to 9.

**GAME ZONE:** Scan the QR code for more daily puzzles and brain teasers

## { WEATHER }

TEMPERATURE ■HIGH ■LOW

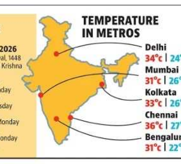
**MONDAY**
Generally cloudy sky with light rain or drizzle
31°c | 22°c

**TUESDAY**
Generally cloudy sky with light rain or drizzle
31°c | 21°c

**WEDNESDAY**
Generally cloudy sky with light rain or drizzle
29°c | 21°c

**ALMANAC**
**Today is 17th August 2026**
03 Rabi ul Awal, 1448
20, Shravana, Krishna Paksha, 05
Samvat 2083
**Sunset:** Monday at 06:39 p.m.
**Sunrise:** Tuesday at 06:07 a.m.
**Moonrise:** Monday at 09:59 a.m.
**Moonset:** Monday at 09:55 p.m.

**TEMPERATURE IN METROS**



# Padikkal, Jurel put India on top

India reach 460/9 in their first innings after home bowlers bag seven wickets on Day 2 of the first Test

**Somshuvra Laha**
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**KOLKATA:** The sun played hide and seek as rain came and went at Galle on Sunday, teasing both teams before scuppering the chance of a full day's play. When the light finally faded on the second day of the first Test against Sri Lanka, India were 460/9, a substantial total although it would not have felt as big as it would have at the start of the day.

The reason was Sri Lanka's response. After being put under sustained pressure on the opening day, their bowlers discovered discipline, length and, increasingly, a method. India added 172 runs from the 43 overs available, but lost seven wickets in the process. The scoreboard tells a story of accumulation, but the day itself was about resistance. And Devdutt Padikkal was at the centre of both narratives.

The left-hander resumed on 131, a century already secured overnight, and spent much of the second session – no play was possible until into the post-lunch session – looking as though he might make Sri Lanka pay for allowing him to settle. His 167 from 230 balls was not merely a large score but an assured performance against spin, built on an understanding of when to go forward and when to stay back.

Statistics say Padikkal played almost half his deliveries against spin off the front foot and half from the back. That was a remarkable approach on a Galle pitch where the traditional response to spin is to smother the ball by getting well forward. Padikkal instead trusted his judgement of length, allowing him to score off the back foot without surrendering control.

"When you have that clarity in terms of what you want to do, I think that brings that confidence in your footwork as well," Padikkal told the broadcaster after the day's play. "I was just looking to make sure that I commit to whatever I do 100%. Even if it's a defensive shot, I want to make sure that I really commit to playing that, so that made my footwork better."

It was, therefore, fitting that his dismissal came from the opposite approach. Left-arm spinner Prabath Jayasuriya, returning to bowl with the second new ball, saw Padikkal advancing and pushed one through flatter and quicker. Padikkal committed himself, missed and was stumped. The wicket was less a consequence of sustained pressure than a reminder of the narrow margin that separates dominance from error in Test cricket. Padikkal had been in complete control, till he wasn't.

Sri Lanka deserved credit for recognising the opportunity. Jayasuriya was the most important bowler on the field, finishing with 4/109 from 39 overs. The figures don't convey the improvement in his bowling as the day progressed. He bowled patiently, varied his pace and, crucially, resisted the temptation to search for extravagant turn. On a surface where accuracy was often more valuable than mystery, he kept India working.

Debutant Keshara Nuwantha, the off-spinner, offered something different. A spinner trusted with the second new ball is unusual enough, a debutant finishing with three wickets against an Indian top order more so. His 39 overs cost 175 runs, but the wickets of Rishabh Pant, KL Rahul and Ravindra Jadeja were worth considerably more than what his economy suggests.

Pant's dismissal was especially revealing. He had already shown the instinct that makes him such a dangerous Test batter, advancing to attack Nuwantha. But the shot lacked shape and elevation, and he miscued to mid-off for 39.

Rahul's dismissal was more instructive. Returning after retiring hurt due to cramp on Saturday, he had negotiated 175 balls for 82, constructing another of those innings in which patience is itself a form of aggression. Nuwantha eventually found a delivery that turned sharply from outside off, cramped Rahul and induced a flick straight to short leg. From 305/2, India were suddenly 319/4.

Padikkal's departure at 357/5 accelerated the collapse. Ravindra Jadeja was trapped leg-before by Nuwantha for 13 before Dhruv Jurel — he was on a valuable 51 — became Jayasuriya's fourth victim. India slipped from 377/5 to 432/6 and then lost three wickets for only 28 runs. Manav Suthar made a useful 24 before lofting Jayasuriya to long on, while Mohammed Siraj's brief 11 included a towering six before he fell to Asitha Fernando's pace.

However, India remain favourites from this position. Their spin attack should eventually become a major factor, and the psychological advantage of crossing 450 after losing only one wicket for much of the opening day remains significant. The weather may ultimately prove to be as important as the pitch though. India have the runs, Sri Lanka have some momentum. What neither side has in abundance is time.

**SCORECARD**

**India (1st innings)**
288/2 (o/n)

| | |
|---|---|
| Rahul c Fernando b Nuwantha | 82 |
| Padikkal st D'wella b Jayasuriya | 167 |
| Pant c Dinusha b Nuwantha | 39 |
| Jurel c de Silva b Jayasuriya | 51 |
| Jadeja lbw b Nuwantha | 13 |
| Suthar c Ṛgamage b Jayasuriya | 24 |
| Siraj c de Silva b A Fernando | 11 |
| Yadav batting | 12 |
| Krishna batting | 1 |
| **Extras** (b 4, lb 3, nb 4, w 1) | **12** |
| **Total** (for 9 wkts, 116 ovs) | **460** |

**FoW:** 3-307, 4-319, 5-357, 6-377, 7-432, 8-447, 9-447
**Bowling:** A Fernando 17-1-61-1, Kumara 13-1-76-0, Nuwantha 39-1-175-3, Jayasuriya 39-6-109-4, de Silva 4-0-15-0, Dinusha 4-0-17-0.

India's Dhruv Jurel celebrates his fifty during the second day of the first Test against Sri Lanka in Galle on Sunday. AP

# DPL: Dhull, Joon fifties hand Central Delhi dominant win

**HT Correspondent**
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**NEW DELHI:** Central Delhi Kings produced a destructive batting performance to defeat North Delhi Strikers by eight wickets in DPL at the Arun Jaitley Stadium.

Opting to field, Central Delhi delivered a disciplined bowling display to restrict North Delhi to a modest 150/9 in their 20 overs.

Middle-order batter Bharat Sindhwani top-scored with a 27-ball 34, while Yash Bhatia (24 off 15) and Arjun Rapria (unbeaten 28 off 17) provided late sparks for North Delhi.

Central Delhi's leg-spinner Tejas Baroka led the charge with figures of 2/17 from his four overs, while Gavnish Khurana (2/25), Aatrey Tripathi (2/43), and Abhishek Kumar Yadav (2/37) chipped in with two wickets apiece.

Chasing 151 for victory, Central Delhi Kings launched an absolute carnage. Openers Siddharth Joon and captain Yash Dhull tore the North Delhi bowling attack apart, forging a blistering 140-run partnership in just 45 deliveries for the opening wicket.

Central Delhi players celebrate their win. DDCA

Central Delhi amassed a staggering 112 runs in the mandatory powerplay, completely dismantling the opposition's bowling strategy.

Joon led the onslaught with a sensational 76 off just 24 balls, featuring six fours and eight massive sixes at a strike rate of 316.67. Dhull was equally ruthless, smashing 69 off 24 deliveries with nine boundaries and four sixes. Central Delhi won with 63 balls to spare.

# Scheffler leads by two after Rd 3 in Memphis

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**MEMPHIS:** Scottie Scheffler settled in after a rough start Saturday for a 2-under 68, giving him a two-shot lead over Sam Burns and Sungjae Im in the FedEx St. Jude Championship going into a final round where so much is at stake from the top to the bottom of the leaderboard.

Scheffler is trying to break a streak of five runner-up finishes and five other top 4s since his lone victory this year in his first tournament of 2026.

He was at 13-under 197 and will be in the final group with Burns, his closest friend in golf, who got back into the mix with a 62. His year has been marked by close calls in the U.S. Open and British Open, but Burns has no victories to show for it. This will be the first time they are paired together in the final group.

"It's always a little weird just because I want him to have success so much and I think he wants the same for me," Scheffler said. "Tomorrow we'll go out there and play our game and see where things finish up at the end of the day. It will be competition like normal."

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## Djokovic feels the heat in Cincinnati

**CINCINNATI:** Novak Djokovic suffered from punishing heat and humidity on Saturday but made a match of it before falling 2-6, 6-4, 6-4 to Thiago Tirante in what could be the Serb's last appearance at the ATP-WTA Cincinnati Masters. The second-round battle lasted for more than two and a half hours, and it proved too much for the 24-time Grand Slam champion who was playing his first match since he lost to Jannik Sinner in the Wimbledon semi-finals more than a month ago.

## Musiala collapses during friendly

**MUNICH:** Bayern Munich were yet to give an update on Sunday about the condition of Jamal Musiala, who collapsed the day before during a friendly game against Leipzig. The 23-year-old Musiala fell to the field shortly before the end of the match, causing alarm among his teammates before medical staff rushed to his side. They attended to the player before one of them eased the tension by raising a thumbs-up, news agency DPA reported.

## SC Delhi enter Durand Cup semis

**RANCHI:** SC Delhi produced a remarkable second-half comeback to defeat debutants FC Raengdai of Manipur 5-1 and storm into the semi-finals of the Durand Cup football. After Chongtham Kishan Singh's (9th) stunning long-range strike had put Raengdai ahead, substitute Joseph Sunny's (57th, 67th) second-half brace turned the game around. Rodriguinho (82nd), Juan Sebastian Pena (90+3) and Augustine Lalrochana (90+8) were the other SC Delhi scorers.

## PLAYERS TO WATCH OUT FOR

### WOMEN'S SINGLES

**AN SE YOUNG (KOR) WORLD NO.1**
The South Korean has dominated women's singles in recent years. The 2024 Olympic and 2023 world champion is the player to beat. The top-seed at this Worlds. An has accumulated five titles this season and led Korea to Uber Cup gold

**AKANE YAMAGUCHI (JPN) WORLD NO.2**
The tenacious Japanese star is still going strong. The 29-year-old won her third world title in Paris last year to tie Spaniard Carolina Marin's record. She has had an impressive run in 2026, reaching six finals with three wins

**PV SINDHU (IND) WORLD NO.9**
The 2019 world champion has five medals in the Worlds, making her a force even at 31. Though the last medal came four editions ago, her resurgence in 2026, winning her first big title in four years (Japan Open), raises hopes

### MEN'S SINGLES



**SHI YU QI (CHN) WORLD NO.1**
The reigning champion and top seed arrives having won his first Asian Championships gold and after helping claim the Thomas Cup. But Shi, 30, can start shakily and the men's singles field is tough. He faces India's sensation Ayush Shetty, whom he beat for the Asian title



**KUNLAVUT VITIDSARN (THA) WORLD NO.2**
Paris Olympics silver medallist Kunlavut peaks nicely at major events. When it comes to the Worlds, the 25-year-old has been a formidable force with three successive finals. He won the title in 2023 and silver in 2022 and 2025. The second seed he will be hungry to stamp his supremacy

**LAKSHYA SEN (IND) WORLD NO.14**
Known for his big-stage temperament, he leads India's hopes in men's singles. At the All England, he beat Chinese stars Shi Yu Qi and Li Shi Feng on way to the final. On his day, he can beat the best. The 2021 Worlds bronze medallist will be raring to shine on home turf

# Worlds: Sindhu, Sen lead India's charge in singles

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**NEW DELHI:** Conversations on the eve of a major championship and body language reveal much about the mindset a player brings into the tournament. There are prodding questions from the media about the build-up, revisiting past demons and head-to-head records. The difference is stark in how an accomplished player and a newcomer, who might be concentrating hard to shut out all the background noise, react.

PV Sindhu's poise a day before the BWF World Championships reflected her stellar career. Her legacy is intertwined with the tournament. For three successive editions, from 2017 to 2019, she made it to the final, eventually becoming the world champion by beating long-time Japanese rival Nozomi Okuhara in Basel, winning her fifth and last medal. It has been a struggle for Sindhu, 31, in the last few years, but this season with the Worlds coming home, Sindhu seems to have found fresh energy.

The Japan Open victory last month ended her two-year title drought. "It's almost seven years since I won a medal at the World Championships, and I hope to get a medal here. I am really excited to have a World Championships in front of a home crowd. The Japan win has given me a lot of confidence. I am hoping for good crowd support and will take one match at a time," said Sindhu.

At the Worlds, her journey began in 2013, when she took out two formidable Chinese players — then defending champion and Olympic medallist Wang Yihan and Wang Shixian — and claimed bronze. Thai Ratchanok Intanon beating the feared Li Xuerui broke China's back and halted their golden run, which included 15 world titles in 19 editions.

A new generation of players had swept into world badminton, taking the sport to an exciting level and giving rise to rivalry after rivalry. That included Sindhu, Saina Nehwal, Carolina Marin, Okuhara, Intanon and Akane Yamaguchi, and later Tai Tzu Ying of Chinese Taipei and Korea's An Se-young, the world No.1. Since Wang in 2011, China has not won a women's singles title in 10 editions. The simmering rivalries that have shaped women's singles for more than a decade will continue in here, starting Monday.

Every defeat Sindhu suffered made her stronger, and she recalls some of those moments that shaped her career. The blockbuster 2017 final against Okuhara, where the two battled for almost two hours, was a moment of great heartbreak but also pushed her become the player she is.

"Every medal at Worlds was a different experience for me, starting with bronze in 2013 and 2014, then two silver medals and then gold. The transition happened in such a wonderful way. There were moments that made me stronger, like when I lost the 2017 final after playing a very hard-fought match, one hour and 50 minutes, against Okuhara in Glasgow and I lost (the decider) 22-20. That was hard. I was very hard on myself because I was almost there. I lost again in 2018 after having the lead in the first game. And when I won the gold, it was an amazing moment."

A podium finish at home would be the icing on the cake for her. As she begins her campaign against Sophia Nobel on Monday, she will count on her experience.

"Earlier, women's singles was more attacking and faster. The game is always evolving. It is now longer rallies and staying on court for longer periods. This requires a lot more patience. I am more experienced at dealing with drift, controlling the shuttle. When things don't go exactly as planned, you have to adapt. And the hunger for the sport has not changed. I still have that hunger, and I know that I can still do it."

Like Sindhu, Lakshya Sen also pushes himself more on the big stage. Having reached the All England final this year where he beat Shi Yuqi, Lakshya would be looking to make a mark here. A bronze medal at the 2021 World Championships was the first breakthrough for him. "I try and peak during these weeks of the year. When you are playing so many tournaments, it's hard at times to be at your physical best all the time, but a World Championships is when you want to come in fresh and sharp," said Lakshya.

Lakshya will face Collins Valentine Filimon of Austria in his first match of the 64-player draw on Tuesday.

In men's singles, Ayush Shetty will be the first Indian in action on Monday, against defending champion Shi Yuqi. Shetty has created ripples this season, winning an Asian Championships silver medal and producing some big wins along the way. But here he will have a tough match up first up. Shetty has lost to the world No.1 twice but has also pushed him close, and a blockbuster opening from the young Indian would be a perfect start for the hosts.

Treesa Jolly (R) and Gayatri Gopichand. HT ARCHIVE

# Treesa-Gayatri set for Worlds quest after injury return

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**LONDON:** When the year started, India's premier women's doubles pair, Treesa Jolly and Gayatri Gopichand, were operating in sync, showcasing their rapid style that previously carried them to a career-best ranking of world No.9 last year.

However, on April 1, an injury halted their momentum during a training session. "While practicing, I had this ankle twist. When we took the MRI, it showed two ligament tears and two higher grade muscle tears," Treesa told HT. It required an immediate pause on their progress. For Treesa, recovery demanded utmost patience. Seven weeks of complete bed rest followed by rehabilitation. In total, she was sidelined for nearly three months.

"That was a struggling point. It feels so bad when you get injured and miss a lot of tournaments. Our ranking also went down which created a little bit of doubt (in my mind)," said the 23-year-old.

Throughout the downtime, her support network was pivotal. Chief coach Pullela Gopichand provided constant guidance while Gayatri, his daughter, ensured her partner felt no undue pressure to rush back. "Gayatri was very supportive. She was telling me, 'Take your time and come back.' All the support I got from her and the coaches helped me figure out all those things more easily," she said.

While Treesa was undergoing rehabilitation, Gayatri focused on maintaining her physical condition to ensure they could hit the ground running on her partner's return. "For Treesa, overcoming an injury is a journey for sure, mentally and physically. But for me, for those 2-3 months, I just wanted to practice and keep myself fit so that when she's back... it's not easy to start off. It's not really easy to come back and push to that extent," Gayatri told HT.

Among the tournaments they missed, the two most important ones were the Asia Championships and Uber Cup, following which their ranking dipped from No.20 in January to 58 in June.

Once Treesa's ankle healed, the duo made a strategic decision to enter the Philippine International Challenge in Manila, stepping down a grade to re-establish match fitness. The move paid off as they navigated through the field to capture the title.

The pair has regained the momentum at the right time, in the build-up to the BWF World Championships that kicks off in New Delhi on Monday. Playing in front of a home crowd brings a unique dynamic, but both players view the fans as an advantage.

"We are really excited that it's happening in India. This is our first time playing such a prestigious tournament in India. The hometown fan base... that gives us an extra boost of energy rather than pressure," said Treesa.

The Worlds presents an early test as they are slated to face Spain's Paula Lopez and Lucia Rodriguez in their opener.

"Everyone at the Worlds is going to play at a decent level. No one is easy. We've played them before once (the Indian pair won). I definitely think we have a good chance this time," said Gayatri.

# India women hold contenders China

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**MUMBAI:** At the final hooter, there were contrasting reactions in both dugouts. India chief coach Sjoerd Marijne led a wave of high-fives among his players and coaching staff while his Chinese counterpart Alyson Annan was stony-faced as she stood in a dugout filled with forlorn expressions.

The India women had just held China to a 2-2 draw in their opening Pool D clash at the hockey World Cup. The match held significance beyond the World Cup given that both the countries are expected to vie for the gold medal at the Asian Games next month with the title winner earning a direct berth for the 2028 LA Olympics.

But Sunday's game at the Wagener Hockey Stadium in Amstelveen, Netherlands, was a match between an India team on the rebuild and a world No.4 China team that is a frontrunner for the title.

HOCKEY WORLD CUP
AUGUST 15 TO 30

Three points at the end of the match would have been a wholesome bonus for India, for whom this match was a litmus test, to see where they stand against the 2024 Paris Olympics silver medallists.

What transpired in the opening exchanges may have been surprising, but not necessarily not on the cards. India women, who failed to qualify for Paris and were relegated from the Pro League but made their way back to the competition by winning the Nations Cup, were on the front foot. The passes were accurate, the movements quick and threatening. And that one shot by Navneet Kaur, from an acute angle just inside the shooting circle, was as accurate as it could get.

Neha Goyal played in a short pass from the right flank and Navneet used the pace to hit it towards the goal first-time. The shot threaded the needle, evading three defenders, a teammate, and a diving Liu Ping in the Chinese goal to creep into the far post.

India's Deepika Sehrawat in action against China. FIH

For all their recent disappointments, India were up inside eight minutes. Then they defended with discipline and control as China started to see more of the ball while searching for an equaliser.

An error of judgement by Shilpi Dabas – she pushed Zhong Jiaqi – gave the opponents a penalty stroke, which Zhang Ying converted to Savita's left. Still, India attacked with purpose and defended with discipline.

In the 25th minute, India's other in-form player, Deepika Sehrawat, made it 2-1 with a fortuitous drag-flick that deflected off two Chinese players before flying past the goalkeeper into the net. This was Deepika's seventh goal in her last six games. China found their second equaliser in the 39th minute through a well-taken Ma Ning penalty corner, a drag-flick like Deepika's. But they could not find the winner despite launching wave after wave of attacks.

The main reason for that was the spirit with which the Indians played. Navneet and Deepika may have go on the scoresheet, but there were performances all around the pitch that were worthy of recognition.

Nikki Pradhan made crucial interceptions, Sushila Chanu stood firm in defence, Lalremsiami – despite being hit by the ball – hassled and harried China's defenders. Navneet often dropped back to help in defence, while Baljeet Kaur made a few important challenges.

England sit at the top of the Pool D standings after their 4-0 victory over South Africa, while India and China are level on points in second place, with South Africa occupying fourth position.

India's Chirag Shetty and Satwiksairaj Rankireddy during a training session. SANCHIT KHANNA/HT

# Where Padukone, Modi and a generation made their mark

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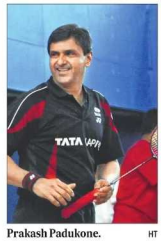
**NEW DELHI:** From the legendary Prakash Padukone to the late Syed Modi, the venue for the BWF World Championships here carries a rich legacy of Indian badminton. Back in the day, the Indira Gandhi Indoor Stadium, then known as the Indraprastha Indoor Stadium, was the country's only air-conditioned venue for badminton and witnessed some of the sport's most memorable moments.

The 1982 Asian Games was one such occasion. Modi won a singles bronze, India's first individual badminton medal at the Asian Games, after a fantastic run that included a clash with Indonesian legend Liem Swie King. Though Modi lost that closely fought match, his bronze marked a significant moment for Indian badminton. India went on to win five bronze medals in 1982 Asiad. Padukone was deemed ineligible as he was then a professional player.

Another historic moment came during the 1988 Thomas Cup qualification, when India beat Japan to emerge the Asian Zone winner. They overcame strong teams such as Japan and Thailand and broke into the top eight badminton nations. Padukone stepped up in singles and doubles, where he partnered Uday Pawar, while Modi and a young U Vimal Kumar handled the singles responsibilities and produced some big wins.



Prakash Padukone. HT

"It was a big moment for Indian badminton back then," recalls Vimal. "We qualified for the Thomas Cup Final in 1988, beating Japan and Thailand. Those were big teams. Prakash played doubles with Uday Pawar, and I played the second singles with Modi. That was Modi's last Thomas Cup," Vimal told HT.

The venue had hosted the Asian Zone Thomas Cup qualification in 1984 as well with Padukone and Modi competing. The big indoor arena also had a unique feature — a partition that could be lowered to make the huge hall more compact for badminton.

Vimal, who has seen the stadium from close quarters and also won a national title there, remembers those days vividly.

"After the Asian Games, there were many badminton competitions hosted at this venue. In those days, having an air-conditioned stadium was a big deal. There used to be a partition that would come down, and it was huge. We have played many matches, from the Thomas Cup to the National Championships."

For Vimal, however, Modi's 1982 Asian Games bronze remains the venue's most significant badminton memory.

"Syed Modi's achievement was the biggest, winning a bronze medal at the 1982 Asian Games. He lost a very close match to Liem Swie King. That was a big moment and a great match. He was leading 13-7 in the third game, and then from there, he lost. That's one of the best matches he played against Liem Swie King."

India went on to win five medals in that edition of the Asiad. Leroy D'Sa and Pradip Gandhe won silver in men's doubles, while the men's and women's teams also won bronze medals. D'Sa and Kanwal Thakar Singh won bronze in mixed doubles as well.

# B'desh make history with first Test win in Australia

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**DARWIN:** A dominant Bangladesh stunned Australia to win the opening Test by nine wickets in Darwin on Sunday for a historic first-ever Test victory on Australian soil.

After bowling Australia out for 284 and needing 57 to win, the visitors cruised past the total when Mominul Haque slashed Beau Webster to the backward point boundary.

Unfancied Bangladesh dominated a full-strength Australia throughout and the margin of victory will send shock waves through the cricketing world. "This is the biggest win so far for Bangladesh in any format," captain Najmul Hossain Shanto said. "Going forward we want to do something special. I'm very happy, proud of myself and the way the boys played. We did a lot of hard work."

Bangladesh's Mehidy Hasan Miraz poses with fans. AFP

After bowling Australia out for 198 in the first innings, the visitors always looked the more likely to win. They kept the pressure on throughout Sunday and didn't panic when Cameron Green (104) brought up his third Test ton after lunch on Day 4.

Green got no real support from his teammates and the Bangladeshis kept taking vital scalps to leave Australia on the ropes, with Mehidy Hasan Miraz taking 5-66.

Najmul said the shock win was the result of Bangladesh players, especially the fast bowlers, putting more emphasis on red-ball cricket. "Five years ago pacers didn't want to play Tests. But they want to play, want to perform, want to be world-class. That is the mindset they now have."

# Wehrlein crowned Formula E champion

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**LONDON:** The 2025-26 Formula E World Championship concluded with a chaotic season finale at the ExCeL Circuit here on Sunday, crowning Porsche's Pascal Wehrlein world champion for the second time, the German having won his first in 2023-24.

Wehrlein arrived here third in the standings with 141 points. He trailed championship leader, Andretti's Jake Dennis, who had 146 points, and Jaguar TCS Racing's Mitch Evans, who was second with 144 points.

However, Wehrlein achieved a turnaround this weekend winning Saturday's opening race. And despite a 14th place finish on Sunday, the German snatched the title as he finished with 169 points, ahead of Dennis (164) and Evans (160).

### Double for Mahindra

The weekend also marked a significant milestone for Mahindra Racing as the Gen3 era drew to a close. The Indian manufacturer, which secured the first pole position of the Gen3 era in 2023, claimed the era's final pole position when Nyck de Vries topped Sunday's qualifying session.

Although Mahindra could not convert that pole into a race victory, the team enjoyed a spectacular double podium finish with de Vries claiming second and Edoardo Mortara finishing third.

This end-of-season result secured third place for Mahindra Racing in the team championship, matching their best-ever finish in the 2016-17 season.

"We came into the weekend with a very clear objective, which was to finish third in the team's championship. We raced as a team today. So, happy to be on the podium together," said De Vries after the race.

Jaguar TCS Racing won the teams' championship with 288 points ahead of Porsche (271).